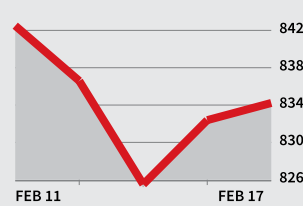


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AI PUSH.

Nvidia will partner with India's largest manufacturers to build AI factories for design and manufacturing **p12**

COSTLIER BARREL.

Compelled curbs on Russian crude to raise Indian refiners' average oil cost by \$1.5-2/bbl **p7**

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QUICKLY.

INTERIM BUDGET

TN projects fiscal deficit at 3% of GSDP in FY27



Chennai: Tamil Nadu reiterated its commitment to fiscal consolidation, with the fiscal deficit in the interim budget estimates for 2026-27 projected to decline to 3 per cent of GSDP (3.45 per cent in the previous fiscal), Finance Minister Thangam Thennarasu said on Tuesday. **p9**

BIOASIA 2026

CEOs turn focus onto high-value products

Hyderabad: To further harness global opportunities in pharma and life sciences, the Indian industry needs to move up the value chain to become a capability leader with focus on high-value products, according to industry captains. The journey towards this end has just begun and may take a decade or more to achieve tangible results, said panellists discussing the 'Future of pharma and biotech over the next five years', during the CEO Conclave at BioAsia 2026 here on Tuesday. **p8**

India's sovereign push gathers pace as local firms roll out AI models

USER TO BUILDER. BharatGen, Gnani.ai and Sarvam launch language, voice and real-world AI tools

Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi

India's push for sovereign AI took concrete shape on Tuesday as BharatGen, Gnani.ai and Sarvam unveiled new models spanning language, voice and real-world interfaces, signalling a shift from being a user of global artificial intelligence tools to building domestic AI infrastructure aimed at government services, health-care, education and agriculture at population scale.

The three players demonstrated that their models are better localised for Indian use cases than global models.

KEY PLAYERS

BharatGen launched its Param2 — a 17-billion parameter model that supports 22 Indian languages. This 'Mixture of Experts' (MoE) foundational model is trained extensively on Indian data and is optimised for multiple languages. At the summit, BharatGen is also showcasing sector-focused demos developed with government and industry partners.

LEVERAGING AI

- BharatGen launches Param2, a 17-billion parameter 'Mixture of Experts' model supporting 22 Indian languages
- Gnani.ai introduces a voice-to-voice AI model



- Inya VoiceOS works by directly consuming and generating speech tokens, capturing phonetics, semantics and intent
- Sarvam launches AI-powered smart glasses, which is named Sarvam Kaze

Similarly, Gnani.ai launched a voice-to-voice model capable of contextual understanding while preserving emotional tone. Gnani.ai joins a select group of companies worldwide to build this architectural capability.

Unlike traditional voice-to-text systems, Inya VoiceOS consumes and generates speech tokens directly, and thus encodes and decodes phonetics, semantics and intent behind the speech. It also handles overlapping speech and mid-sentence corrections.

Besides releasing a slew of AI capabilities across voice, OCR and other products over the last 10 days, Indian AI model maker Sarvam on Tuesday upped it a notch with its own AI-enabled hardware.

Sarvam launched AI-

powered smart glasses Sarvam Kaze. "Sarvam Kaze moves intelligence from the screen to the real world. You wear it. It listens, understands, responds and captures what you see. And you can build custom experiences for it with the Sarvam platform," Sarvam Co-

founder Pratyush Kumar said in a post on X, teasing a launch as early as May.

MORE CAPABILITIES

Rishi Bal, Executive VP and Head of BharatGen, told *businessline* that their previous model was about 3 billion parameters, and the one

launched now is 17 billion, and they have achieved a 6x increase. "The roadmap will continue with us growing the size and the capabilities of the models as well," he said.

Further, sovereign AI makers have also shown willingness to grow the entire ecosystem of Indian AI companies by putting their play-book out there.

"We will release all of our models in open source. We will release new benchmarks, release new datasets and also recipes for developers to finetune their model," Bal said.

More reports p2, p3

'Build sovereign AI models to meet our strategic needs'

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

At a time when India is organising one of the biggest global artificial intelligence (AI) conclaves, the government on Tuesday made it clear that the way forward is to build sovereign AI models to meet strategic requirements and reduce the dependence on foreign large language models.



Ashwini Vaishnaw

The ambitious push comes a day after Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited the

pavilions of Indian companies and start-ups that are developing local LLMs such as BharatGen, Sarvam.AI, gnani.ai, Wadhvani AI, Aalekh AI and HanuAI.

The models, tested and measured on Indian parameters, have been rated better than many of the large global models, IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw told reporters here.

Details p2

India, France amend double taxation pact; Modi, Macron launch 'Year of Innovation'

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai



FOSTERING TIES. In Mumbai on Tuesday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and French President Emmanuel Macron virtually inaugurate the Tata-Airbus H125 light utility helicopter final assembly plant in Karnataka **ANI**

The two leaders also virtually inaugurated the final assembly plant of H125 helicopters, set up jointly by Airbus and Tata Advanced Aerospace Systems in Karnataka.

Later, they launched the 'India-France Year of Innovation' centred around AI, digital technologies and start-ups.

France is among India's closest friends with a strategic partnership that is nearly three decades old.

"Relations between India

and France are special. France is one of India's earliest strategic partners. Together with President Macron, we have brought unprecedented energy to these relations," Modi said while announcing the special global strategic partnership on Tuesday.

In his remarks, Macron said, "Indo-French relations are based on openness, trust and ambitions. The two countries believe in an open and free Indo-Pacific and don't support hegemonic or-

der." He said the two countries are working together in defence and space, and added that France supports technology transfer to India.

External Affairs Ministry's Additional Secretary Piyush Srivastava said there were discussions between the two leaders (Modi and Macron) on various issues like defence, civil nuclear co-operation and counter-terrorism. "There is also a strong focus now on people-to-people ties," he added.

BEL-SAFRAN JV

India and France signed an agreement on reciprocal deployment of defence personnel at each others' units.

A joint venture between Bharat Electronics Ltd and Safran for production of Hammer missiles was also announced.

Other initiatives include setting up of an Indo-French Centre for AI in health, a Centre of Digital Science and Technology, and a National Centre of Excellence for Skilling in Aeronautics.

India-US deal: Pulses off factsheet but still on the table

Amiti Sen
Prabudatta Mishra
New Delhi



Despite the White House last week dropping the mention of Indian pulses from its revised factsheet on the US-India interim trade deal framework, they are not off the negotiating table, sources said.

"There is no agreement yet on pulses in the interim trade agreement, but negotiations on the matter are still on. Once the negotiating teams meet face-to-face in Washington next week, the final commitments may be sorted out," a source tracking the matter said.

CHOUHAN PLAYS CONG

Interestingly, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh

Chouhan on Tuesday criticised the Congress for resisting the trade deal with the US and opposing the import of pulses, cotton and apples, which he said the country needs.

"Whatever we produce, like wheat, rice or maize, will not come (from the US)... we all know that in the case of pulses, we are not self-sufficient today; consumption is higher than production. It is required to be imported to

meet demand. Whatever product we require (to import), why is there an objection if it comes from any country?" Chouhan said at an event in Jaipur.

There was no mention of pulses in the India-US joint statement on the framework for an interim trade deal issued on February 6. But a factsheet issued by the White House soon after included "certain pulses" in the list of farm items on which India had supposedly agreed to eliminate or reduce tariffs. This led to protests from some farm groups and heated political debates in India, following which the reference to pulses in the factsheet was dropped.

AWAITING CLARITY

"The White House factsheet was supposed to reflect what

was contained in the joint statement. Because the joint statement did not mention pulses, it was edited from the factsheet. But one has to understand that there are about 1,800 traded tariff lines in agriculture and everything cannot be included in the joint statement. The negotiations are on and there will be more clarity on many things, including pulses," another source said.

At a media briefing following the joint statement, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal mentioned "lentils" among agricultural items that India had been importing from the US for many years, including during the UPA government's tenure, where some concessions had been offered as part of the deal.

Also read p10

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‘Building sovereign AI models to meet our strategic needs is the way forward’

New Delhi: Mihup, an Indian voice AI company, announced a collaboration with Qualcomm Technologies, to co-create and take to the market multilingual, enterprise-grade Voice AI solution for the BFSI sector optimised for on-device AI platforms.

LOCAL LLMs

The ambitious push comes a day after Prime Minister Narendra Modi also made a special visit to the pavilions of many Indian companies and start-ups that are developing local LLMs such as BharatGen, Sarvam.AI, gnanai, Wadhvani AI, Aalekh AI and HanuAI.

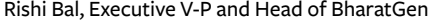
The models which have been launched and are part of the sovereign bouquet have been tested and measured on parameters. They have been compared with global models in so many parameters and have actually been rated better than many of the large global models, Ashwini Vaishnav, Minister of Electronics and IT, told re-



TO INVEST \$217 BILLION
The Minister also said India expects to see an investment of around \$217 billion in the next two years across five layers of the AI stack, which shows the commitment of

He added that 50 deep-techs will emerge from India in the coming years, and in the next one week, the government will be placing an order for 20,000 graphic processing units (GPUs). “We are expecting another 20,000 GPUs over and above the 38,000 GPUs that we already have in the common compute layer. In another

BHARATGEN MANDATE
BharatGen is a consortium under the Technology Innovation Hub at IIT Bombay and an Indian government-funded multimodal and large language model initiative for Indian languages, supported by the Department of Science and Technology (DST). Its mandate is to develop ef-



efficient AI models for Indian languages. At the AI Summit, BharatGen launched Param2 — a 17 billion parameter model that supports 22 Indian languages.

This multilingual ‘mixture of experts’ foundational

Enterprises are defining their AI needs within the artificial limits of what is possible today, even though multilingual AI systems have the potential to unlock new

and much larger markets," said Bal.

Companies often tell us first that English and Hindi use cases are sufficient, but then somebody chips in to add Tamil, Telugu, Bengali and Marathi and it goes on this way, he adds. They then realise that the language constraints have stopped them going into newer markets, he adds. "The government has seen this from the outset; they completely get it," he adds.

BharatGen says it has a pipeline of customers with pilots on in education, fintech and in governance. "Given the size of the Indian economy and its position in the world, I think we have to have 'big boy aspirations,'" added Bal.

At a time when all eyes are on the Indian IT services industry and its potential to survive the AI era, Silicon Valley investor Vinod Khosla said India may be underestimating the impact of AI on IT services and that the sector in its current form may not even exist by 2030.

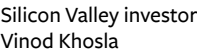
“It’s clear to me that people in India don’t believe that the whole idea of IT services will go away. By 2030, there will be no such thing as IT services. There will be no such thing as BPO. Those are gone,” said Khosla while speaking at a fireside chat at the AI Impact Summit here.

“There will be new kinds of services based on AI that

Indian companies can form and bring to the rest of the world because India has the best engineers, the best talent and education," he added. There will be disruptions and the industry has to make the transition, he noted.

He also went a step ahead to question whether people will even need any jobs in the future. "The question you have to ask is will anybody need jobs? I think by 2050, it will be very clear nobody needs jobs. Because production of goods and services [will become] near free, so you won't need jobs," he said. People will do jobs, but they will have much more time to spend with their kids, with their parents and pursue their passion, he added.

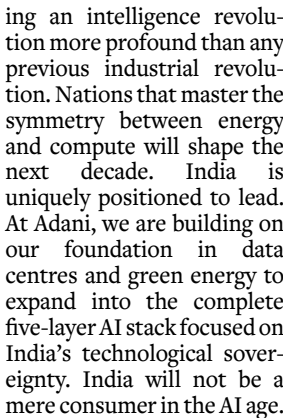
Speaking about how India



should adapt to the changing employment situation, Khosla said the general view is that the actions of AI will be very different in different countries, and it will be guided by politics. "Politics, not a technical capability, will be the key determinant of what is adapted and what's not adapted," he said.

‘RIGHT MOVE’
He also lauded India’s policy decisions and investments

The Adani Group on Monday unveiled one of the world's largest integrated energy and compute investments, committing \$100 billion to develop renewable energy-powered, hyperscale AI-ready data centres by 2035.



We will be the creators, the builders and the exporters of intelligence,” said Gautam Adani, Chairman, Adani Group.

The roadmap builds on AdaniConnex’s existing 2 GW national data centre footprint and charts a path towards a 5GW deployment, which the group describes as the world’s largest integrated data centre platform.

The architecture combines renewable power generation, transmission infrastructure and hyperscale AI compute in a single coordinated ecosystem, with energy generation, grid resilience and high-density processing capacity developed in parallel.

MAJOR DEALS

Landmark partnerships in-

clude Google for a gigawatt-scale AI data centre campus in Visakhapatnam, additional campuses in Noida, and Microsoft facilities in Hyderabad and Pune.

The group is also deepening its partnership with Flipkart to develop a second AI data centre tailored for digital commerce, high-performance computing and large-scale AI workloads.

Facilities will support high-density compute clusters and next-generation AI workloads using advanced liquid cooling systems and high-efficiency power architecture.

Dedicated capacity will support Indian large language models (LLMs) and national data initiatives, ensuring long-term data sovereignty.

Infosys has introduced AI-first value framework to help global enterprises unlock AI at scale. According to CEO and MD Salil Parekh, this move opens a new frontier in IT services, and positions the company to tap into an incremental AI-first services opportunity worth \$300-400 billion by 2030.

He said although there is a perception that AI-driven productivity will compress IT services revenues, it is now clear that the opportu-

As India readies to scale up its AI data centre ambitions, with capacity expected to reach 6-8 gigawatts (GW) by 2030, government officials and industry leaders stressed on comprehensive resource adequacy planning, meticulous modelling exercises coupled with long-term firm power availability, and regulatory certainty with the Centre and States coming on the same page.

The rise of AI computing is fuelling the demand for high-performance accelerators, which are specialised

ated servers that consume more electricity. For instance, according to MIT's Lincoln Laboratory, creating an image with generative AI uses energy equivalent to charging a smartphone.

Besides, power consumption is also rising significantly. In 2024, the International Energy Agency (IEA) said power consumption by data centres has grown 12 per cent annually over the last five years.

At the India AI Impact Summit 2026, government officials, hyper scalars and industry leaders said there is a sort of uncertainty around future electricity demand

from AI-enabled data centres and hyper scalers. Understanding the future power consumption requirement from data centres will require creating various scenario-based models to explore alternative pathways and offer perspectives on timelines relevant for decision-making in the energy sector.

Participating in a panel discussion at the summit, Grid India CMD Samir Chandra Saxena said: "These are data centres we consider as very dense and intense loads unlike bulk loads that we used to have at the distribution level. In fact, the scale

at which these are growing. At present, by 2030, the penetration will probably be equivalent to one of the state demands that we are seeing, maybe 8-10 GW.”

From a grid operator’s perspective, Saxena emphasised on comprehensive planning for infrastructure. “The other side is resource adequacy. With such large chunks of demand, they [data centres] must be obligated to meet resource adequacy requirements, not only in terms of primary energy requirements, but also for reserve and balancing requirements,” he added.

Abhishek Ranjan, CEO of

distribution utility BSES also stressed on comprehensive resource side planning. The requirement is for stable long duration of electricity-generation sources.

NUCLEAR POWER

Scaling up nuclear power is still some time away for India. So, for hyper scalers, the need is to leverage several sources such as captive generation besides grid-connected power.

"So, just like the Central Electricity Authority creates a national plan for transmission for normal loads, I believe there will be a national plan for possible sites where

data centres can open, and that has to be pre-decided. Otherwise, it may lead to chaos and unnecessary adding of wires here and there, sub optimal organisation, and therefore the burden of tariff on the end consumers," he explained.

businessline.

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Building sovereign AI models is not just important from a geopolitical standpoint, but also to deliver real value to enterprises, said Ganesh Gopalan, Co-founder and CEO of Gnani.ai, a voice-first small language model-maker.

“Even keeping the geopolitics aside, it is very difficult to bring value to enterprises unless you have your own models and are able to customize those models for your customers in order to make real business impact,” Gopalan told *BusinessInsider*.

“We don’t believe in the concept of a [LLM] wrapper. We believe AI is not ad-

can win by being a wrapper company; it is going to be inaccurate with no guarantees on latency,” he said.

Gnani.ai on Tuesday announced the deployment of its Inya VoiceOS, a five billion parameter voice-to-voice foundational AI model built under the India AI Mission. The model is a preview release, in line with the startup’s plan for an upcoming flagship 14 billion parameter voice-to-voice foundational AI model.

"Voice is the most natural language of communication. What is unique about our model is that it not only understands what's being spoken, but also understands the emotions behind the conversations, and that is very valuable for enterprises today," he noted. "Particu-

MACHINES TAKE OVER. Qualcomm showcased robotics technologies, including humanoid systems, at the summit ^{ANI}

CHENNAI

businessline.

WEDNESDAY - FEBRUARY 18 - 2026

A CH-CHE

QUICKLY.

Bharat1.AI's Humanity-First AI City vision in Bengaluru

Mumbai: Bharat1.AI unveiled its vision to build a Humanity-First AI City in Bengaluru — a city-scale research and infra initiative designed to advance foundational Agentic and Physical AI systems. The first phase will take shape through the B1 AI Superpark, a 500,000 sq. ft. AI research and innovation campus in Sarjapura, Bengaluru. *OUR BUREAU*

Mastercard's secure agentic commerce transaction

Mumbai: Mastercard demonstrated a fully authenticated agentic commerce transaction on its payment network, expanding its global agentic commerce payment capabilities in the Asia Pacific. *OUR BUREAU*

NeuroDx to submit Manas-1 brain AI model

Mumbai: NeuroDx.ai will submit its 400-million-parameter AI model to the Centre for evaluation and validation, under emerging standards for sovereign AI assets. It named the model Manas-1, a 400-million-parameter Brain Language Model trained on over 25,000 subjects and 60,000 hours of EEG data. *OUR BUREAU*

India should be among top 3 global AI superpowers, says Narendra Modi

SMART ADOPTION. Leveraging AI mindfully, with a strategic lens, helps address deep developmental challenges: PM

Asian News International
New Delhi

As the India AI Impact Summit 2026 commenced in the national capital, marking the first time that a global convening of this scale on artificial intelligence is being organised in the Global South, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in a special interview to ANI, underlined the guiding spirit of the summit under the umbrella “*Sarvajan Hitay, Sarvajan Sukhaye*” (“Welfare for all, happiness for all”).

Edited excerpts:

India is hosting the AI Impact Summit 2026 for the first time anywhere in the Global South. What's the vision of this Summit?

Today, AI stands at a civilisational inflection point. It can expand human capability in unprecedented ways, but it can also test existing social foundations if left unguided. That is why we have deliberately framed this Summit around Impact that ensures meaningful and equitable outcomes, not just innova-

“Our vision is clear: Artificial intelligence must accelerate global development while remaining deeply human-centric

NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister



tion. The guiding spirit, “*Sarvajan Hitay, Sarvajan Sukhaye*”, reflects India's civilisational philosophy. The end goal of technology should be ‘Welfare for All, Happiness of All’. Technology exists to serve humanity, not replace it.

As the first global AI summit hosted in the Global South, India is creating a platform that amplifies under-represented voices and development priorities.

Our vision is clear: AI must accelerate global development while remaining deeply human-centric.

How do you see AI's role in Viksit Bharat 2047?

AI represents a transformative opportunity in India's journey towards Viksit Bharat 2047. Leveraging AI mindfully, with a strategic lens, helps address deep developmental challenges while creating entirely new economic opportunities, enabling inclusive growth, bridging the urban-rural divide and expanding access to opportunity.

In healthcare, AI is already delivering impact. We are seeing AI-based solutions addressing early detection of tuberculosis, diabetic retinopathy, epilepsy and many other ailments at primary and district health centres.

In education, AI-powered personalised learning plat-

forms in Indian languages are helping students in rural and government schools receive customised academic support. In a unique initiative, Amul is leveraging AI to reach 36 lakh women dairy farmers across thousands of villages, providing real-time guidance in Gujarati on cattle health and productivity, empowering grassroots women producers.

In agriculture, the Bharat Vistaar initiative aims to integrate AI into crop advisory, soil analytics and weather intelligence, helping farmers make better, localised decisions.

Even in heritage preservation, AI is enabling the digitisation and interpretation of ancient manuscripts, unlocking India's civilisational knowledge systems.

At a time when the world is worried about AI deepening divides, India is using it to dissolve divides.

In your speech at AI Action Summit 2025 in Paris, you emphasised the bias and limitations of AI. From now and then, has the scenario

changed? How do you see India addressing this issue?

The concerns regarding bias and limitations in AI remain deeply relevant. As AI adoption accelerates, the risks also scale. AI systems can inadvertently perpetuate biases related to gender, language and socio-economic background.

For India specifically, we face unique challenges and opportunities. Our diversity — linguistic, cultural, regional — means that AI bias can manifest in ways that might not be obvious in Western contexts. An AI system trained primarily on English data or urban contexts may perform poorly for rural users or speakers of regional languages. The positive development is that India is beginning to address this more systematically. We're seeing increased focus on creating diverse datasets that represent India's plurality, greater emphasis on AI development in regional languages, and growing research on fairness and bias in Indian academic institutions and tech companies.

Discussions encouraging, we are nearing consensus on most pillars: Abhishek Singh

Sindhu Hariharan
New Delhi

“We are very near to achieving consensus on most of the objectives, and we should leave it to the top leaders to announce it on the main day,” Abhishek Singh, Additional Secretary, MeitY, CEO, IndiaAI Mission, said.

“Across all of the seven pillars we have moved forward, we have a considerable degree of consensus on the way forward. And most countries have agreed to it,” Singh told *businessline* on Tuesday.

“Added to that, we are also launching all our sovereign models, and Sarvam is showcasing its model today,” he added.

SEVEN PILLARS

The 2026 India AI Impact Summit, taking place from February 16-20 in New Delhi, is structured around seven core pillars — and it aims to achieve consensus from all participating global delegations on these.

These seven areas are Human Capital, Inclusion for Social Empowerment, Safe and Trusted AI, Resilience, Innovation and Efficiency, Science, Democratising AI



Abhishek Singh, Additional Secretary, MeitY, CEO, IndiaAI Mission

Resources, and AI for Economic Growth and Social Good.

BIG BUZZ

Speaking about the hassles faced by the invitees on day 1, Singh said that the buzz was very big, and it had been overwhelming.

“We did expect (the kind of interest) but not as much. Yesterday was in fact a low-key day with no star speakers, so it seems there was a lot of curiosity on day 1,” he said.

“But the quality of discussions in the sessions has been absolutely brilliant,” he said, urging people to catch up on as many sessions as they could online.

Army used AI tool to anticipate Chinese aggression in Arunachal: Lt Gen Rana

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

India successfully used small artificial intelligence (AI) software to anticipate and repulse an unprecedented Chinese attempt along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in Yanste, Arunachal Pradesh, Lt General Dinesh Singh Rana, Commander-in-Chief, Strategic Forces Command, said on Tuesday.

Lt Gen Rana emphasised the broader role of AI in re-shaping war games, strategic doctrines and the national security ecosystem during his address at a session at the India AI Impact Summit 2026.

AI FORESIGHT

He recalled that during his earlier stint as General Officer Commanding of 4 Corps (Gajraj Corps) in Arunachal Pradesh, hinting at the December 2022 physical face-off between the Indian Army and Chinese PLA, they used small AI software with low capability to analyse an emerging situation, triggered by an unpreceden-

ted attempt made by China. That helped the Army to predict the timing of Chinese soldiers' approach in Yangtse — a disputed territory held by India — and successfully deploy troops in the region close to the LAC to thwart Chinese ingress and prevent casualties, he told the audience, highlighting the low-hanging fruit of AI-powered prediction tools.

TECH SHOWCASE

The Army also showcased indigenous dual-use AI technologies at the AI Summit, which, it stated, can deliver significant value in education, disaster response, cybersecurity, transportation safety and digital infrastructure protection.

For instance, “AI Examiner” is an AI-enabled automated evaluation system that can be integrated into any learning management system for creating assessments, analysing submissions, generating scores and providing structured feedback to trainees, the Army said.

It has also come up with SAM-UN (Situational



Lt General Dinesh Singh Rana, Commander-in-Chief, Strategic Forces Command

Awareness Module for UN Operations), an indigenous web-based platform that integrates geospatial intelligence, structured reporting, and AI analytics to provide unified real-time situational awareness for mission planning, monitoring, coordination and rapid response.

This is ideally suited for disaster management centres, emergency coordination hubs, and smart city control rooms.

Similarly, “EKAM” an AI-as-a-Service tool, that is secure, modular, indigenous, air-gapped cloud platform providing unified access to AI chat, document and presentation generation,

multilingual translation, summariser, RAG and specialised bots for multimedia generation.

It ensures access to compute resources while maintaining full data sovereignty.

WEATHER INTELLIGENCE

Another solution is PRAK-SHEPAN, an AI-driven military climatology and disaster prediction system.

PRAKSHEPAN is India's first hybrid military climatology decision-support system capable of predicting landslides, floods, and avalanches three to seven days in advance using multi-agency scientific datasets, terrain intelligence, and AI/ML-based modelling.

Developed in collaboration with national scientific agencies and the Ministry of Earth Sciences, it provides highly accurate and location-specific hazard forecasts for sensitive operational regions, the Army informed.

Among other tools developed are: Facial Recognition System, Driver Fatigue Detection, Vehicle Tracking System, and Deepfake Video Detection System.

AI job market to hit ‘hockey stick’ growth phase after churn: Prosus India

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

India still has about three more years of job churn before hitting the upper end of the hockey stick in the job market, Sehraj Singh, Managing Director of Prosus India, told *businessline* while sharing insights from its “AI for All: Catalysing Jobs, Growth, and Opportunity” white paper.

Launched in partnership with the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) and the Boston Consulting Group at the India AI Impact Summit 2026 on Tuesday, the white paper suggests a blueprint for the next phase of jobs, productivity, and inclusive growth in India. Based on a series of pre-summit multi-sectoral consultations, the report examines four key sectors — healthcare, education, manufacturing, and agriculture — and job opportunities therein.

SIX-YEAR CYCLE

Singh described the job market in the AI age as following

a six-year cycle: the first two years marked by an “overkill of job loss”, two years of understanding the right equilibrium, and two years of employing that equilibrium to achieve better outcomes.

RESKILLING PUSH

“This one year would be a little bit of overkill and then two years of figuring out that right balance. But the two years after that are going to be the upper end of the hockey stick because everyone will have understood the different career paths and usage paths that we can create,” Singh said.

Anxiety over this overkill phase surfaced during consultations, with participants asking probing questions about significant job displacement, Singh noted. However, he argued that automation processes would still require upskilling, training, and education.

“With AI as a tool, there are many more jobs and tasks that can now be done in India that earlier were not being done at all. That will enable a lot of interest-



Sehraj Singh, MD, Prosus India

ing job opportunities,” he said.

EMERGING ROLES

Singh was optimistic about engineers working on coding to shape AI models to make them learn specific tasks better, as well as logistics workers, as AI is expected to drive commerce.

The white paper also identified emerging roles in AI supervision, data operations, advisory services, diagnostics, compliance, and digital enablement, reframing AI from displacement risk to a catalyst for productivity and employment.

In healthcare, it expects AI to act as a workforce multiplier by enabling triage automation, diagnostic support, portable digital records, fraud detection, and predictive public health planning, thereby improving consistency without replacing clinicians.

SECTORAL IMPACT

Instahyre, too, noted the impact of AI beyond the IT sector as manufacturing and heavy industries increase demand for digitally fluent talent.

In agriculture, which still employs over 40 per cent of India's workforce, precision farming and data-led decision systems are creating new opportunities in agritech and analytics.

Educational institutions prefer AI-literate educators capable of hybrid and digital delivery.

“Even in such insulated sectors, the hiring filter has changed: adaptability, applied AI capability, and problem-solving now outweigh traditional pedigree alone,” said Sarbojit Mallick, Co-Founder, Instahyre.

Ayush Pavilion draws visitors with citizen-centric innovations

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Ayush Pavilion set up by the Ayush Ministry at the on-going AI Impact Summit-2026 is drawing visitors with a unique display of citizen-centric AI innovations focused on holistic health and wellbeing, officials said.

The pavilion is presenting a comprehensive architecture of the Ayush Grid – India's flagship digital public health platform for traditional medicine.

MAISP PORTAL

A key component of this ecosystem is the ‘My Ayush Integrated Services Portal’ (MAISP), the master digital portal developed under the Ayush Grid.

Envisioned as the backbone of the digital Ayush ecosystem, MAISP operationalises the vision of ‘One Portal: Complete Ayush Ecosystem’ by integrating healthcare services, capacity building, medicinal plants research and development, and Ayush drug administration, education and outreach on a unified platform.

The portal, launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the second WHO Global Summit on Tradi-

A key component of this ecosystem is the ‘My Ayush Integrated Services Portal’, the master digital portal developed under the Ayush Grid

tional Medicine held in Delhi last December, streamlines access to authentic traditional medicine services for citizens and institutions alike. Reaffirming the ministry's commitment to aligning traditional knowledge systems with emerging technologies, senior leadership emphasised the transformative potential of responsible AI in public health, the officials said.

Ayush Minister Prataprao Jadhav said, “Guided by the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Ministry of Ayush is committed to ensuring that artificial intelligence becomes an instrument of ‘*Sarvajana Hitaya, Sarvajana Sukhaya* – welfare and happiness for all. Through the Ayush Grid and AI-enabled innovations, we are building a digital public infrastructure that

strengthens transparency, expands access, and integrates India's timeless health knowledge with future-ready technologies for inclusive and affordable healthcare.”

Highlighting the institutional and governance perspective of this digital transformation, Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha, Secretary, Ministry of Ayush, said, “The Ayush Grid architecture and the My Ayush portal represent a paradigm shift in how traditional medicine is delivered, documented and digitally integrated.”

“By embedding AI tools into research, education, service delivery and regulatory systems, we are ensuring standardisation, interoperability and evidence-based advancement of Ayush systems in alignment with global practices,” he said.

Explaining the practical application of AI across citizen services, Naman Goel, OSD, Ayush Grid, said, “We are demonstrating AI-powered chatbots and other flagship initiatives at the Ayush Pavilion, including the Yoga Posture AI, a computer-based solution that enables users to check, correct and accurately perform asanas, thereby enhancing precision, safety and accessibility in yoga practice.”

India Deep Tech Alliance to mobilise \$1 billion for AI start-ups

Our Bureau
Chennai

The India Deep Tech Alliance (IDTA), a deep tech-focused consortium of investors, corporates and ecosystem stakeholders has announced that it has allocated over \$1 billion of the \$2.5 billion in committed capital from its members to AI start-up funding.

The funds, which will be deployed over the next three years, will help Indian AI companies scale faster, commercialise breakthrough IP and compete globally at every layer of the stack.

Launched in September 2025, IDTA has worked to mobilise long-term capital and ecosystem support for India's deep tech founders. Out of a total commitment of more than \$2.5 billion, IDTA members have already deployed \$110 million in 50 companies.

RESEARCH REPORT

The organisation also released *The AI and Deep Tech Investments Landscape: 2026 Edition*, a research report analysing investment activity and ecosystem trends across India's AI and deep tech landscape.

Eternal announces strategic tie-up with OpenAI

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Eternal Ltd and OpenAI on Tuesday said they have entered into a strategic collaboration to advance AI capabilities across Eternal's businesses. This includes platforms such as Zomato, Blinkit, District, Hyperpure and its AI-native venture, Nugget. The collaboration will focus on AI deployments across Eternal's apps, partner platforms and internal systems.

The company said it is also considering integrating OpenAI's latest coding models, including GPT-5.3-Codex, within Stitch, its in-house automation and developer orchestration platform.

PLATFORM INTEGRATION

It will also work with OpenAI's Enterprise API platform to explore new ways customers and partners interact with its platforms, deploy advanced AI tools within partner applications and integrate advanced coding models into its in-house AI orchestration platform.

“From high-leverage areas like software development to real on-ground implications of influencing operations, we are learning about the evolving implementations of newer and developing tools in the AI landscape. We are



Albinder Dhindsa, Group CEO, Eternal

happy that this collaboration with OpenAI will open up even more surface area for us to learn and innovate”, said Albinder Dhindsa, Group CEO, Eternal.

AI DEPLOYMENT

Eternal said that it is strengthening AI infrastructure across its consumer and enterprise platforms, building AI as foundational infrastructure across its commerce ecosystem. “Through this collaboration, the company intends to deploy OpenAI models across select use cases, including AI-assisted workflows for merchants and delivery partners, contextual AI assistants embedded within partner portals, and experimentation around next-generation search and discovery interfaces. These efforts are aimed at making AI useful in everyday decisions and workflows, while maintaining the reliability and speed its platforms require,” it added.



Beyond the AI code

Environmental impact, infrastructure hurdles of AI

Niranjana KarthigaiRajan

The Artificial Intelligence (AI) market is growing rapidly and is significantly impacting every aspect of modern life. Companies have started integrating AI widely in their operations, gaining traction in sectors that range from healthcare to agriculture. The future of AI in India will not be shaped by algorithms alone, but also on sustainable infrastructure and strategic foresight.



AI. Energy factor

AI'S ENERGY COSTS

Given their computational intensity, AI systems are contributing to an increased carbon footprint, higher water consumption and growing pressure on energy resources. According to the study “Navigating New Horizons” published by United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP) in July 2024, a single request made to ChatGPT consumes up to 10 times more energy than performing a standard Google search.

At this juncture, as Google is working on Project Suncatcher to launch datacentres into low-earth orbit and running them entirely on solar energy — the direction of AI infrastructure is clearly shifting towards sustainability.

Strengthening AI infrastructure through enhanced energy efficiency and greater integration of renewable energy sources will be crucial to ensuring long-term competitiveness and technological leadership.

INDIA MUST ACT NOW

The US and the European Union (EU) are among the leading jurisdictions addressing the environmental impact of artificial intelligence through proposed and adopted measures, such as the Artificial Intelligence Environmental Impacts Act of 2024 and the EU’s Artificial Intelligence Act, which establishes harmonised rules for AI governance.

China has also introduced a series of AI-specific regulations, while South Korea enacted the AI Basic Act in January 2026, making it one of the first countries to implement a comprehensive national AI law.

Although India has taken certain measures — such as amending its IT Rules in 2026 to mandate AI content labelling and address online harms — it has yet to introduce a comprehensive AI framework that systematically

regulates risk assessment, transparency, liability, safety, and ethical standards across sectors.

India must move towards enacting dedicated legislation to regulate AI’s environmental impact by increasing transparency about AI energy usage, encourage greener data centres and ensure sustainability standards.

AGENDA AHEAD

China’s trade surplus crossed a record \$1.2 trillion in the first 11 months of 2025 driven by its dominance in global value chains in high-technology manufacturing sectors such as electric vehicles, batteries, and solar panels.

China has emerged as a monopoly over Rare Earth Elements (REEs), contributing to 60 per cent of global production in the last five years and 92 per cent of global refining capacity. Thus, with its dominance across reserves, production, and exports China has gained the bargaining power to shape the global flow of these critical resources.

It is crucial for India to build a resilient processing capacity and value-chain integration and ensure that it is not left dependent. The REEs are critical components in clean energy technologies like e-vehicles and high-tech India should similarly prioritise securing a stable supply of REEs to power AI and semiconductor industries.

To remain globally competitive, India must increase funding for mineral exploration, nurture domestic manufacturing processes, strengthen its human resource pool to build advanced AI applications, and bring in a comprehensive AI law.

India must now embark on the long march towards technological sovereignty.

The writer is an independent researcher

Achieving UPI’s ‘1-billion’ dream

CASH-LESS. To acquire another 600 million users, a concerted push in rural and semi-rural regions will be needed



GANGA NARAYAN RATH
CHIRAYU SHARMA

The active users of UPI are about 400 million. We are targeting one billion users. So.....there is a lot of scope, there is a lot of distance that we need to travel,” said T Rabi Sankar, Deputy Governor of RBI, while speaking at Global Inclusive Finance India Summit, recently.

India’s transition to a \$10-trillion digital economy by 2026 has been anchored by the aggressive infrastructure push by the Big Three: PhonePe, Google Pay, and Paytm. The “scan-and-pay” revolution has moved far beyond simple crossword-like stickers. As of January 2026, 709 million active QR codes blanket the nation — a 21 per cent jump in just one year. This expansion is being spearheaded by these big three.

PhonePe currently commands the lion’s share, processing a record-breaking 9.81 billion transactions in December 2025 alone, effectively controlling 45.4 per cent of the market volume.

The battle has now shifted to hardware, specifically the “Soundbox” and POS terminals. These voice-confirmation devices have crossed 12.1 million units nationwide, acting as the ultimate trust-builder for micro-merchants.

The scale of this infrastructure is transforming Indian commerce. In the first month of 2026, the UPI ecosystem recorded a staggering ₹28,334 billion in total value across 21.7 billion individual payments. With the RBI now eyeing one billion digital users, these fintech giants are no longer just apps; they are critical utility providers for a digital-first India.

BILLION RUPEE GAMES

The widespread adoption of UPI is the outcome of an aggressive, billion-dollar cash-burn strategy by the Big Three, who collectively ‘invested’ over \$3 billion



PAYMENTS PUSH. Scaling up UPI will need a marketing and infra thrust

MURALI KUMAR K

(around ₹25,000 crore) to dominate India’s digital payment landscape. This capital was deployed to build scale rather than profits. With infrastructure in place, these firms are now shifting focus toward monetisation through high-margin offerings like credit on UPI and high-value transactions, transforming early investments into a sustainable, data-driven financial platform.

Despite being first movers post demonetisation, Indian banks and smaller TPAPs have steadily lost ground in the UPI ecosystem. The core reason lies in an “innovation versus utility” divide: banks treated UPI as a

low-return back-end obligation, bearing an estimated ₹2 per transaction under the zero-MDR regime, while fintech players like PhonePe and Google Pay pursued it as a billion-dollar customer acquisition and data dominance strategy.

Reluctant to operate in a prolonged zero-revenue model, banks avoided heavy upfront investment, resulting in a severe hardware and experience gap. Although banks like SBI and HDFC continue as the critical settlement layer, their apps face higher technical decline rates and legacy constraints, while private platforms achieve success rates as high as 99.2 per cent through aggressive spending on infrastructure and edge processing.

Consequently, even as millions of bank accounts are linked to UPI, front-end control of India’s digital payment economy has shifted to private players, leaving banks as invisible pipes in a system they once pioneered.

The first wave of India’s digital transformation has reached near-total

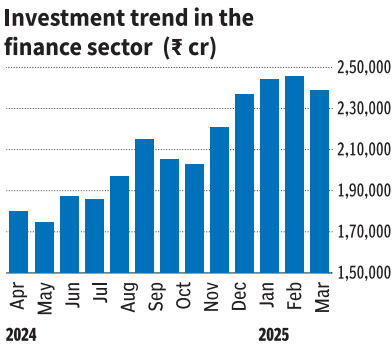
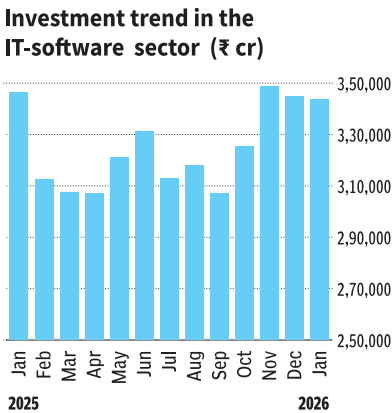
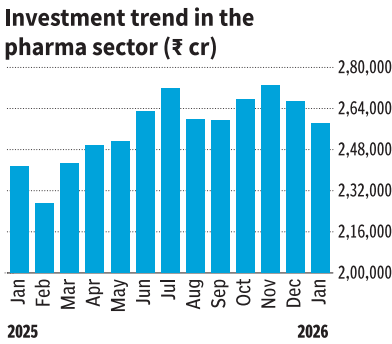
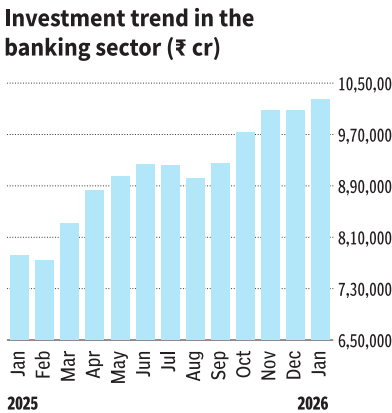
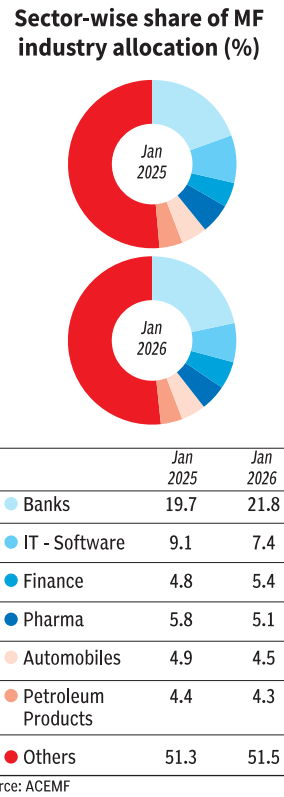
Nearly 45,000 villages lack consistent 4G coverage, while another 1.1 lakh localities struggle with weak signals, leading to a rural UPI failure rate

STATISTALK.

Compiled Dhuraivel Gunasekaran | Graphic Visveswaran V

Decoding mutual fund sector allocation trends

Within equity-oriented mutual funds, Banks, IT-Software, Finance, Pharma and Automobiles remained the most preferred sectors. Banks continued as the largest allocation at nearly 22% of equity AUM, also recording the biggest absolute rise of 31% in the last one year to ₹10.24 lakh crore. Finance exposure too increased both in value and portfolio weight (4.8% to 5.4%). In contrast, IT-software saw a clear underweighting. Allocations were inconsistent through the year and the sector’s share dropped sharply from 9.1% to 7.4%. Pharma exposure rose in absolute terms but declined in portfolio share (5.8% to 5.1%). Here’s how mutual fund industry allocations shifted over the past one year



thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

February 18, 2006

Rangarajan panel for cut in Customs duties on petrol, diesel

Oil companies and consumers could breathe easy if the Rangarajan committee recommendations submitted today to the Petroleum Minister, Mr Murli Deora, are accepted. The committee, set up by the Government to make recommendations on the pricing and taxation of the petroleum products, has made certain radical proposals such as giving oil companies the freedom to fix the prices of petrol and diesel through the trade parity pricing mechanism rather than the existing import parity pricing.

‘Armed’ with IIM course, head to new careers

The Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Lucknow has a new breed of alumni — retired officers from the armed forces who have undergone a 24-week programme. The first batch that passed out last year has secured good placements in the corporate sector in areas such as telecom, finance and retail.

Numaligarh Refinery looking at IPO

Numaligarh Refinery Ltd is actively considering coming out with a Rs 700-800-crore IPO. The company, a BPCL subsidiary, is discussing the issue prospects with merchant bankers.

saturation in metros and Tier-1 towns, which account for the core of the nation’s 400 million active UPI users. Recent data reveal that in Tier-1 cities, the transaction mix has matured significantly: approximately 52 per cent of urban UPI activity is now driven by merchant (P2M) payments rather than P2P transfers.

Achieving one billion users requires deep penetration into rural and semi-urban “Bharat”, where onboarding the next 600 million users will demand sustained marketing and infrastructure investment.

While the government has budgeted ₹2,000 crore for FY27 reimbursement, the actual ecosystem cost over the next two years could reach ₹8,000-10,000 crore, driven by the ₹2-per-transaction burden, rural literacy campaigns, and multilingual support across 22+ languages. This push will also hinge on expanding feature-phone solutions such as 123Pay and voice-based “Hello! UPI”, which require heavier server capacity and AI-wave infrastructure.

THE FUTURE

Experts argue that India will need a predictable cost-recovery framework — either through higher subsidies or a nominal fee on large payments — along with coordinated public-private investment in rural education, fraud awareness, and last-mile infrastructure to ensure the journey to one billion users does not stall.

Available data indicate that nearly 45,000 villages lack consistent 4G coverage, while another 1.1 lakh localities struggle with weak signals, leading to a rural UPI failure rate higher than the urban average. During peak hours, regional and small finance banks report failure ratios of 3 to 5 per cent, compared to just 0.01 per cent for top-tier private banks.

Overcoming this “digital dark spot” is essential, as nearly 60 per cent of consumer expenditure in semi-urban regions still defaults to cash due to fear of a “transaction pending” screen at a crucial moment.

Rath is a former central banker, and Sharma is an independent researcher. Views are personal

On businessline.in

When agentic commerce meets young India

AI agents proactively personalise and automate every stage of commerce, reducing friction and cognitive load for users, point out **Amal Chandra** and **Vinayakan Sajeiv Beena**

<https://tinyurl.com/yc7ffkij>

Meeting steel industry’s energy security challenge

Green hydrogen could be a viable substitute of met coal for domestic steel firms, says **Saumya Nautiyal**

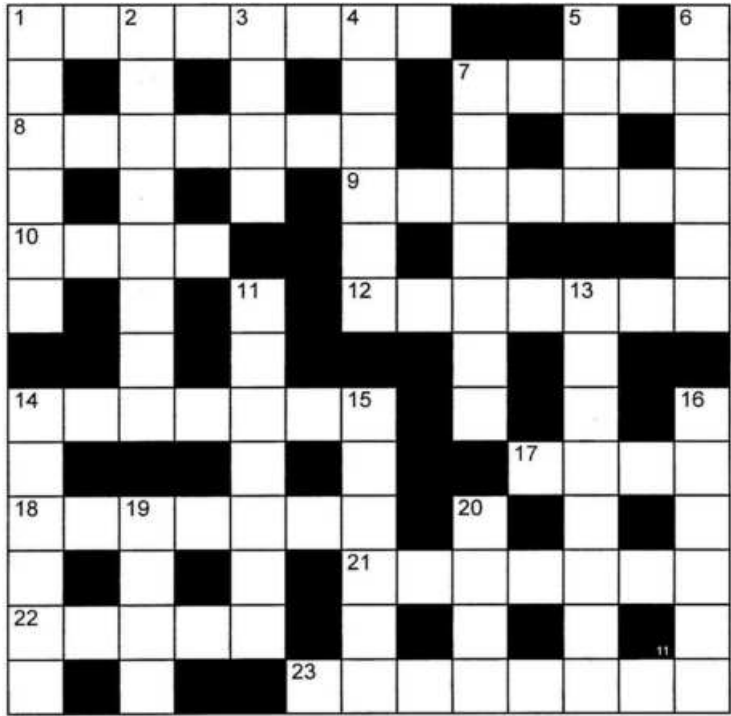
<https://tinyurl.com/5dkre9b9>

Digital sovereignty is imperative for Indian enterprises

Digital sovereignty is about engaging and participating in the global economy from a position of strength, argues **Sandip Patel**

<https://tinyurl.com/bdhnxb3hu>

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2619



EASY

ACROSS

01. Suicidal Japanese WW2 pilot (8)
07. Cook slowly in boiling liquid (5)
08. Suite, set of variations (7)
09. Showed hilarity (7)
10. Therefore (L) (4)
12. Boring, wearisome (7)
14. Confused (7)
17. Yarn with hard core, trimming (4)
18. Man, machine fastening with hammer-headed bolts (7)
21. List out singly (7)
22. Willow twig (5)
23. One picking players for team (8)

DOWN

01. Cured herring (6)
02. Orange-yellow flower (8)
03. Work in wool (4)
04. Enthusiast, fanatic (6)
05. To launder (4)
06. Awnings (6)
07. Bruised, brayed (7)
11. Long, perhaps cylindrical pillow (7)
13. One taking hopeful view (8)
14. Soft tissue in hollow of bone (6)
15. Laugh at, mock (6)
16. Come into view (6)
19. It carries blood back to heart (4)
20. Surrender, yield to (4)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

01. Pilot on a self-destruct mission (8)
07. How to steal the eggs one will cook (5)
08. Set it a trap with a set of variations (7)
09. Sounded amused by lad, huge as he might be (7)
10. Therefore it’s right to enter one’s self (4)
12. Wearisome, the way it suited nothing inside (7)
14. With 3-D, mule got in confusion (7)
17. Hard-core yarn of how I’m taken in by family practitioner (4)
18. He joins plates that might revert to one inside (7)
21. Makes it seem I could list things one by one (7)
22. What basket-maker uses is ore crushed out of shape (5)
23. One picking team might let score sort him out (8)

DOWN

01. One sleeping fish to split open and cure (6)
02. How to dig moral out of a flower (8)
03. Make things woolly using nitrogen in the outfit (4)
04. He is too enthusiastic to laze about (6)
05. Get clean of rough water boat leaves behind (4)
06. Degrees of colour in sunglasses (6)
07. Used a pestle to do end up like this (7)
11. Cold chisel one may have under one’s pillow (7)
13. One such as Pangloss? Stop it: I’m changing! (8)
14. A worm that turns round the right courgette (6)
15. Pour scorn on egghead in having dried out (6)
16. Seem to change a paper around (6)
19. It carries blood in style (4)
20. To give way to it is a bit of a precedent (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2618

ACROSS 7. Corresponding 8. Landing-gear 12. Deluge 14. Smirch 16. Caress 18. Garner 19. Indemnified 23. Consolidation

DOWN 1. Doll 2. Cran 3. Aspire 4. Forges 5. Adze 6. Gnar 9. Aileron 10. Arrange 11. Char 12. Dock 13. Gas 15. Moa 17. Sample 18. Grinds 19. Icon 20. Dish 21. Iota 22. Doom

QUICKLY.

DCM Shriram's demerger entities debut on bourses



Bengaluru: Shares of DCM Shriram Fine Chemicals and DCM Shriram International, the two demerged entities from DCM Shriram Industries, began trading on stock exchanges on Tuesday. DCM Shriram Fine Chemicals hit the lower circuit of ₹47.50 on the NSE and BSE. DCM Shriram International ended at ₹52.21 on the bourses, after opening at ₹49.50. The market debut marks the formal completion of the demerger that split operations of DCM Shriram Industries into three separately-listed companies aimed at sharpening business focus and unlocking shareholder value. **OUR BUREAU**

Sensex, Nifty close higher as buying in PSBs, IT stocks lifts sentiment

TURNAROUND SEEN. Gradual upward move likely for market in the next few months, says Kotak Institutional

Madhu Balaji
Bengaluru

Equity benchmarks pared early losses to close modestly higher on Tuesday, supported by buying in PSU banks and IT stocks amid steady global cues. The BSE Sensex rose 173.81 points to end at 83,450.96, while the Nifty 50 gained 42.65 points to 25,725.40. Gains in index heavyweights such as Adani Enterprises, Infosys and Larsen & Toubro helped lift sentiment, even as the broader market traded in a range-bound manner and sectoral trends remained mixed. “Domestic markets traded in a range-bound manner, attempting to recover recent

losses triggered by lingering concerns over AI-led disruptions,” said Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, noting selective bottom-fishing in IT stocks and outperformance in PSU banks.

AI-DRIVEN SHIFTS “In the near term, sentiment is likely to remain cautious as investors monitor global developments around AI-driven shifts. However, a resilient GDP outlook, and a stabilising rupee may provide support to renewed FII inflows,” Nair added. The market could see a gradual upward move in the coming months after a prolonged phase of stagnation, supported by an improving earnings outlook but tempered by elevated valuations in consumption sectors, according to Kotak Institutional Equities. Analysts expect FY27 and FY28 net profits of the Nifty 50 index to grow 16 per cent and 15 per cent after a muted 8 per cent growth in FY26. Stronger GDP growth, recovering consumption de-



LEADING THE WAY. Gains in index heavyweights such as Adani Enterprises, Infosys and L&T helped the market **REUTERS**

mand and export tailwinds should act as a key driver. However, Kotak cautioned that weaker global growth and margin pressures in automobiles and consumer staples remained downside risks. Volatility index India VIX cooled off sharply ending be-

low 13 mark. Broader market indices ended in the green, with both mid-cap and small-cap gauges closing higher. Sectoral performance remained mixed — Nifty PSU Bank and Nifty IT led the gains, while Nifty Metal and Nifty Realty slipped into negative territory.

GLOBAL OPTIMISM Bank Nifty extended its strong outperformance, closing near the 61,200 mark with a gain of 0.37 per cent, Sudeep Shah, Head-Technical and Derivatives Research at SBI Securities, said. Gains in IT stocks were driven by global optimism and domestic triggers, including momentum from discussions around artificial intelligence at the India AI Impact Summit 2026.

Post fall, small-caps offer buy signal: Abakkus MF

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

A significant portion of small-cap universe is currently trading well below historical peaks, offering investors a potential entry window as valuations reset after recent corrections. According to internal research by Abakkus Mutual Fund, nearly half of small-cap stocks within the ₹2,000-₹34,700 crore market-cap bracket are trading roughly 40 per cent below all-time highs, reflecting the impact of market volatility but also opening scope for strategic long-term allocation.

OUTPERFORMANCE Small-cap stocks tend to be more volatile than large-caps, but research highlighted by Abakkus MF shows they have delivered stronger long-term returns. SIP investments tracking the Nifty Smallcap 250 have

generated a CAGR of about 17 per cent since September 2016, compared with roughly 12 per cent for the Nifty 50, with the small-cap index also outperforming over three- and five-year periods. Between CY19 and CY25, the market capitalisation of small-caps expanded sharply from ₹16 lakh crore to ₹83 lakh crore. “A meaningful portion of companies in the ₹2,000 crore to ₹34,700 crore m-cap bracket is now available at improved risk-reward levels. Most importantly, exposure to sunrise industries and varied sectors that are difficult to access in the large-cap space are majorly available in the small-cap category,” said Vaibhav Chugh, CEO, Abakkus MF. Investors may find opportunities to accumulate fundamentally strong companies at more favourable valuations that are less represented in large-cap indices.

CleanMax Enviro's ₹3,100-cr IPO opens on February 23

Our Bureau
Mumbai

CleanMax Enviro Energy Solutions' ₹3,100-crore initial public offering will open on February 23 at a price band of ₹1,000-1,053 a share. The IPO closes on February 25. The renewable energy company has already raised ₹1,500 crore through a pre-IPO placement from institutional investors, including Jongsong Investments Pte Ltd — an indirect, wholly owned subsidiary of Temasek Holdings — alongside funds such as GSS India Opportunities AIF Scheme I, 360 ONE Special Opportunities Fund, and Steadview Capital Mauritius Ltd.

SELLERS IN OF'S The issue comprises a fresh issue of ₹1,200 crore and an offer for sale of up to ₹1,900 crore by promoters Kuldeep Jain, BGTF One Holdings (DIFC) Ltd and KEMPINC LLP, as well as selling shareholders Augment India I Holdings LLC and DSDG Holding APS. Bids can be placed for a minimum of 14 shares. Of the fresh issue, approximately ₹1,122.6 crore will fund the repayment or pre-



payment of certain borrowings of the company and subsidiaries, with the balance earmarked for general corporate purposes. Its total borrowings stood at ₹8,078 crore as of March 2025. In FY25, the company reported revenues of ₹1,495.7 crore, up 7.62 per cent year on year. EBITDA rose sharply by 36.88 per cent to ₹1,015.07 crore, while it posted a net profit of ₹19.43-27.84 crore, reversing a loss of ₹37.64 crore in FY24. CleanMax, which operates in the commercial and industrial renewable energy space, had an operational, owned-and-managed capacity of 2.80 GW as of October 31, 2025, complemented by an additional 3.17 GW of contracted capacity. The company develops renewable energy plants to supply power to corporate customers under long-term power purchase agreements, with a weighted-average tenure of 22.85 years.

Gaudium IVF's ₹165-cr issue to open on Feb 20

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Fertility services provider Gaudium IVF and Women Health on Tuesday fixed a price band of ₹75-79 per share for its ₹165 crore initial public offering (IPO). The company's public offering will open for subscription on February 20 and conclude on February 24. The bidding for anchor investors will take place on February 18. With this, it will become the first company in the fertility care sector to tap the public markets. The proposed IPO comprises a fresh issue of 1.14 crore shares and an offer for sale of about 95 lakh shares by promoter Manika Khanna. Proceeds from the issue are intended for capital expenditure of ₹50 crore to establish 19 new IVF centres across India, along with repayment or pre-payment of certain borrowings of ₹20 crore, and for general corporate purposes. In January, it filed draft papers proposing a fresh issue of 1.83 crore shares and an OFS of 25.31 lakh shares by the promoter. The current structure reflects a higher promoter stake being offered to investors.

ASK Asset & Wealth gets SEBI nod to enter MF biz

Our Bureau
Mumbai

ASK Asset & Wealth Management Group, a leading player in the investment and wealth management space in India, has received regulatory approval from the SEBI to launch a mutual fund business. It will be the 52nd fund house to join the MF industry, which manages assets worth ₹81 lakh crore as of January-end. ASK Asset & Wealth Management has a four-decade-long legacy in equity markets, with a proven track record of managing capital across market cycles

through its portfolio management services and alternative investment platforms. It will bring this cycle-tested investment philosophy to a wider audience, offering investment solutions across active equity, passive strategies, hybrid and fixed-income products. Sameer Kotichia, Founder & Chairman, said ASK has navigated multiple market cycles with a strong, research-driven approach focused on capital protection and growth.

BLACKSTONE BACKING In 2022, PE funds managed by Blackstone acquired a majority stake in ASK Asset & Wealth Management Group.

Gift City IFSC set for first IPO as XED files RHP with ROC

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

XED, a Mumbai-based global executive education company, has filed its Red Herring Prospectus (RHP) with the Registrar of Companies, completing all regulatory requirements and setting the stage for Gift City's first IPO. The offering is expected to open for subscription in the first week of March. The filing with the RoC follows approvals from the stock exchanges. The IPO will be open to global investors, including NRIs, foreign portfolio investors, and other overseas participants.



John Kalleil, Founder and Managing Director, XED

The anchor investor portion is expected to close by the end of this month. **DOLLAR TRADING** The equity shares will be listed on NSE International Exchange and the India Inter-

national Exchange at Gift City and traded in a dollar-denominated instrument. John Kalleil, Founder and Managing Director, XED, said, “The opening of this IPO is not symbolic; it is strategic. We are raising capital to accelerate global programme expansion, deepen university partnerships and invest in delivery capabilities across key markets. Gift City gives us access to international investors who understand cross-border education businesses and long-term institutional scaling.” While domestic IPOs are open for three days, the Gift City IFSC IPO can remain open for up to 10 days.

‘Our equity returns have improved due to lower module costs’

bl.interview

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai



CleanMax Enviro Energy Solutions scaled back its fundraise from over ₹5,000 crore to ₹4,600 crore for its initial public offering (IPO) on February 23, amid renewable sector headwinds marked by sliding valuations and cautious investor sentiment. Founder and Managing Director Kuldeep Jain speaks about pricing discipline, business model resilience and growth runway.

Edited excerpts:

At the upper band, the valuation is about ₹12,800 crore. How do you defend that number in a cooling market?

If you step back and look at our journey, we have raised roughly ₹4,000 crore of cumulative equity over 15 years, including pre-IPO rounds. At ₹12,800 crore post-money, that represents about three times value creation. This is long-term compounding, not a short-cycle build-up. We believe the valuation reflects our 6-GW platform, long-duration contracted assets and improving project returns. Break up the ₹4,600-crore raise for us.

You are selling shares worth about ₹382 crore. Is that partial monetisation? No. I had taken a personal loan earlier to buy back shares. The proceeds from

Data centres and AI-driven infrastructure are also emerging as strong demand drivers. We believe the structural opportunity remains intact despite near-term valuation resets

KULDEEP JAIN
Founder and Managing Director, CleanMax Enviro Energy Solutions

this sale will go toward repaying that loan. It's balance-sheet housekeeping, not cashing out.

How insulated is your business model from sector volatility? We operate exclusively in the commercial and industrial renewable segment. Our weighted average PPA tenure is about 23 years. The majority of corporates prefer long-term contracts because renewable generation is capital-intensive and non-core for them. That gives us strong revenue visibility and predictable cash flows.

What does your current operating platform look

like and how have the financials evolved? We are a 6-GW platform. Of this, about 2.8 GW was operational as of September-end, and 3.2 GW is contracted and under execution over the next 24 months. We reported ₹1,000 crore in EBITDA last fiscal and ₹635 crore in the first half of the current fiscal. Over the past three years, our EBITDA CAGR has been about 58 per cent.

With the tariffs on a downward trend, do you see returns compressing? Historically, our weighted average dispatch tariff was around ₹4.3 per unit. For projects under construction, it is about ₹3.61 per unit. While customer tariffs have come down, our equity returns have improved due to lower module costs, better wind turbine efficiencies and improved capital structuring. Equity payback for projects commissioned in the past three years is around 2.5 years, compared with a historical average of 3.4 years.

Where do you see growth coming from? Corporates account for nearly half of India's electricity consumption, but only about 7 per cent of that demand is currently met through bilateral renewable arrangements. That leaves a very large headroom. Data centres and AI-driven infrastructure are also emerging as strong demand drivers. We believe the structural opportunity remains intact despite near-term valuation resets.

BROKER'S CALL.

Elara Securities

GMR AIRPORTS (BUY)

Target: ₹140
CMP: ₹99.89
Q3FY26 marked a structural earnings inflection for GMR Airports, driven by tariff-led aero yield expansion at Delhi (DIAL) and steady scaling of non-aero adjacency businesses, resulting in strong margin expansion leading to strong adjusted earnings beat. With Bhogapuram nearing commissioning and major capex behind, leverage is likely to peak in FY26 and net/EBITDA set to moderate from FY27, as EBITDA scales up. Sustained aero realisation, improving non-aero monetisation, and disciplined capital allocation are likely to support cash generation and balance sheet deleveraging in the medium term. GMR Airports is nearing the end of its capex cycle, with net debt at about ₹34,500 crore (ex-FCCB) likely peaking in FY26 and moderating from FY27 as EBITDA scales. Bhogapuram (96 per cent complete) is slated for Q2FY27 commissioning. With limited near-term capex and Hyderabad's expansion (₹12,000-13,000 crore) from FY28, the company is transitioning toward a cash-generation and deleveraging phase. We shift valuation from an airport asset valuation approach to business segment-wise SOTP framework, assigning differentiated EV/EBITDA multiples on FY28E to aero and non-aero segment. We value land-bank at each airport on per acre basis (incremental value of ₹17/share). We expect FY25-28E EBITDA CAGR of 29 per cent. We reiterate Buy with a higher TP of ₹140 from ₹123 earlier.

SBI Securities

LUMAX AUTO TECH (BUY)

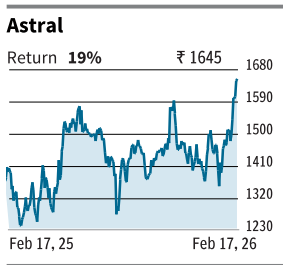
Target: ₹2,210
CMP: ₹1,635.35
Lumax Auto Tech reported Revenue/EBITDA/PAT growth of 40/49/116 per cent y-o-y during Q3FY26. PAT was boosted by one-time deferred tax gain of ₹39 crore on account of merger of GreenFuel Energy with the SPV. Looking at the robust growth during 9MFY26, the management again raised the FY26E revenue growth guidance to 30 per cent from 25 per cent announced at the end of Q2FY26. The EBITDA margin improvement continued with Q3FY26 margin at 13.8 per cent, up 80 bps. EBITDA margin is expected to structurally improve to 20 per cent over the next five years, driven by operational efficiencies, expanding portfolio of high margin components and presence in OEM programmes creating high entry barriers. The two acquired subsidiaries — IAC India and GreenFuel Energy — continue to drive growth for the company. Lumax Auto Tech's revenue from M&M grew 15 per cent during Q3. Growth is expected to bounce back in Q4 as the XUV 7XO scales up production. Recovery in 2W export volumes for Bajaj Auto led to 22 per cent growth for revenue from Bajaj Auto. Integration of GreenFuel Energy along with the increase in share of business has led to 88 per cent/110 per cent growth for Lumax's revenue from Maruti Suzuki and Tata Motors, respectively. The stock is currently trading at a P/E of 33.3x/22.1x/16.1x its FY26E/FY27E/FY28E EPS of ₹48.9/₹73.6/₹101.1 respectively. We raise our target multiple to 30x FY27E EPS of ₹73.6 to arrive at our TP of ₹2,210.

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TODAY'S PICK.

Astral (₹1,645.90): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau



The short-term outlook is bullish for Astral. The 3 per cent rise this week has taken the share price well above the key resistance level of ₹1,593. The region around ₹1,590 will now act as a strong support. A fall below ₹1,590 is less likely, as new buyers can enter the market and limit the downside. The 21-Day Moving Average (DMA) has turned up. This sends a positive signal and strengthens the bullish case. Astral share price can rise to ₹1,720.

Traders can buy Astral shares at ₹1,646 now. Accumulate on dips at ₹1,610. Keep the

stop-loss at ₹1,580. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹1,660 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹1,675. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹1,670 and ₹1,695 when the share price touches ₹1,685 and ₹1,710, respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹1,730. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

25736 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
25670	25600	27800	25940	Go long only above 27800. Stop-loss can be placed at 27760

₹926 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
920	915	934	942	Stuck inside a narrow range. Avoid trading this stock

₹1391 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1370	1300	1435	1470	Wait for dips. Go long at 1375 with a stop-loss at 1365

₹325 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
324	320	328	333	Take fresh longs above 328. Keep the stop-loss at 327

₹272 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
270	267	273	277	Go long only above 273. Stop-loss can be kept at 272

₹1424 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1410	1390	1435	1460	Go short only below 1410. Keep the stop-loss at 1415

₹1215 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1205	1185	1225	1250	Go long on dips at 1210. Stop-loss can be placed at 1195

₹2720 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2700	2670	2760	2800	Go short on a break below 2700. Keep the stop-loss at 2710

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers				
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
L&T	4279.80	20.16	31.02	4.28
Infosys	1391.20	19.66	20.14	4.15
ITC	325.45	15.85	19.69	2.67
Bharat Elec	446.85	6.95	54.78	1.36
Titan	4236.40	5.01	78.91	1.49
State Bank	1213.40	4.82	12.94	4.29
HCL Tech	1482.60	4.81	24.43	1.33
Adani Ports	1566.30	4.24	28.88	0.98
Asian Paints	2437.40	3.99	59.79	1.55
Sun Pharma	1717.10	3.85	37.61	1.55
Maruti Suzuki	15179.00	3.68	31.96	1.70
Adani Enter	2242.90	3.33	18.32	0.50
Bajaj Auto	9626.50	3.14	30.89	0.93
Tata Motors PV	382.85	2.57	52.06	0.68
TCS	2171.40	2.42	20.50	2.37
Dr Reddys Lab	1284.80	2.06	19.42	0.67
Int'lBeeVai	4977.00	1.79	59.92	0.86
Tech Mahindra	1523.80	1.55	32.52	0.92
Wipro	215.69	1.52	16.97	0.52
TataConsumerProduct	1148.50	1.33	77.23	0.64
Bajaj Finance	1075.50	0.82	22.44	2.38
Eicher Motors	8035.00	0.74	41.14	0.94
HDFC Life	705.80	0.45	80.43	0.65
ONGC	271.85	0.26	7.60	0.90
PowerGrid Corp	300.75	0.25	18.02	1.16
UltraTech Cement	1284.00	0.08	49.93	1.31
Max Healthcare	1075.50	0.05	73.08	1.00
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	262.30	-0.18	103.84	0.71
Quality Walls	27.95	-0.29	0.00	0.02
SBI Life	2039.50	-0.29	83.37	0.78
HDFC Bank	925.70	-0.34	18.39	12.07
Apollo Hosp	7601.50	-0.37	58.58	0.67
Coal India	421.55	-0.47	8.73	0.82
Axis Bank	1357.20	-0.69	15.95	3.32
NestleIndia	1285.30	-0.71	75.99	0.79
NTPC	368.40	-0.73	14.39	1.49
JSW Steel	1244.60	-0.74	39.19	1.00
Bajaj Finserv	2044.40	-0.76	32.17	1.00
Grasim Ind	2900.40	-1.03	20.04	0.94
Hind Unilever	2312.30	-1.30	54.03	1.75
Cipla	1343.90	-1.54	23.95	0.64
Kotak Bank	424.45	-1.85	22.46	2.66
Trent Ltd.	4171.90	-2.80	91.56	0.79
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1075.50	-3.64	22.11	1.28
M&M	3489.20	-4.01	25.67	2.66
Tata Steel	203.08	-4.95	27.79	1.43
Hindalco	890.10	-5.50	12.44	1.10
Bharti Airtel	2020.30	-5.56	31.09	4.80
ICICI Bank	1447.50	-6.42	17.78	8.57
Etemad Ltd.	281.50	-8.04	1176.75	1.32
Reliance Ind	1423.00	-20.88	19.69	8.19

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

▲ 372.00 pts.

	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Bank Of Baroda	303.25	59.56	7.98	2.42
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3877.80	49.59	60.33	3.91
Punjab Natl Bank	124.82	43.97	8.03	1.85
Canara Bank	149.11	33.08	7.34	2.16
Adani Energy Solutions .	1030.20	27.84	51.92	1.53
Adanigrreenenergy	1016.80	23.50	90.24	1.34
Power Finance	416.95	22.50	4.12	2.61
Cholamandalamin&Fin	1732.10	21.95	30.16	3.15
United Spirits	1424.00	20.38	60.22	1.81
Rural Elec	358.60	19.11	5.48	1.92
Adani Power	144.35	18.70	24.64	2.46
Divis Lab	6187.50	14.49	66.26	3.38
Britannia Ind	614.55	13.98	61.26	3.11
Godrej Consumer	1214.80	13.28	68.24	2.10
Hero Cycles	519.60	12.80	32.41	2.06
Hindustanuranonatics	424.67	12.24	31.93	3.46
Sunat Industries	1326.60	11.33	78.63	1.39
Hysal Motor India .	2191.20	11.04	30.75	1.34
Baraj Holdings	11217.00	10.91	139.3	2.09
Havells	1434.90	10.37	60.68	1.55
Ambermut	3902.30	9.81	88.87	2.59
Varun Beverages	458.05	9.03	50.59	2.69
Pidlittind	1495.50	7.64	65.77	1.99
Gail (India)	165.75	7.53	12.66	1.92
Indian Oilcorp	175.81	7.40	6.73	2.82
Oil India	113.70	5.25	43.47	1.87
Sarnamdrothersoninternat	132.66	4.66	34.47	2.53
Intl Lombard Cg	1928.20	4.50	34.29	2.00
Cg Power & Ind Sol	690.50	3.61	98.01	2.04
Cap Gemini	374.95	3.49	6.61	3.12
Lic	874.10	3.30	10.82	8.63
Mazagon Dock	236.87	2.35	59.97	1.77
Shree Cement	26370.00	2.21	52.97	1.51
Jindal Steel	1211.00	0.11	61.27	1.94
Baraj Housing Finance .	88.74	-0.25	29.84	0.36
Macrotech Developers	1096.95	-0.80	32.75	1.33
Tonmay Pharma	422.00	-0.97	61.03	1.91
Indian Railway Finance Corp	112.99	-1.02	21.07	0.97
Zydusfisciences	906.65	-2.85	18.15	0.97
Bosch	35370.00	-2.99	37.84	1.32
Siemens Energy India .	2797.20	-3.21	84.33	1.06
Sysm J Energy	487.35	-4.19	32.72	1.12
Ambuja Cements	492.00	-4.94	26.12	1.37
Siemens	3186.40	-7.74	71.57	1.21
Abb India	538.00	-8.18	0.00	1.31
Indian Hotels Co. .	887.75	-8.56	45.23	2.59
DF	639.05	-9.14	35.72	1.76
Indus Zinc Co.	150.10	-16.91	20.08	0.88
Tata Power	378.40	-18.64	21.44	2.73
Vedanta	266.20	-59.04	15.77	4.87

Pts: Impact on index movement

‘Compelled curbs on Russian crude to raise Indian refiners’ average oil cost by \$1.5-2/bbl’

STRONG CURRENTS. Indian OMCs have navigated a highly volatile margin environment over the past three fiscal years: CareEdge report

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Replacing Russian crude oil with a combination of barrels from the US, Venezuela and West Asia will increase the weighted average cost of crude oil by \$1.5-2 per barrel for Indian refiners, impacting their gross refining margins (GRMs).

Ratings agency CareEdge pointed out that the strategic advantage derived from procuring discounted Russian crude oil — at one point accounting for nearly 35-40 per cent of India's crude oil import portfolio — is expected to moderate significantly.

MARGIN OUTLOOK
“Going forward, a compelled

shift away from Russian crude toward a blend of Venezuelan, US and West Asian grades is likely to increase the weighted average cost of India's crude oil sourcing by \$1.5-2 per barrel, directly compressing the GRM premium that Indian refiners have enjoyed in recent years,” CareEdge anticipated.

Hardik Shah, Director at CareEdge Ratings, said the performance of the Indian downstream oil sector is currently driven by the dual engines of high GRMs and healthy marketing margins.

“As we transition into FY27, the narrative is likely to shift from high GRMs to moderate, sustainable ones. While GRMs are expected to moderate from their recent

peak levels due to global supply pressures and realignments in crude oil sourcing, they are likely to settle at \$6-8 per barrel, which is accretive to the historical average,” he explained.

TRADE DYNAMICS
The durability of this trend will depend on global crude prices remaining benign, though they can be susceptible to sudden geopolitical trade dynamics.

With an expected moderation in GRMs and steady fuel retail prices, marketing margin is expected to improve going forward in the medium term, Shah projected.

Indian oil marketing companies (OMCs) have navigated a highly volatile margin environment over the past



DIRECT IMPACT. Gross refining margins fell from a high of \$10-12 per barrel in FY24 to \$4-6 per barrel in FY25 and further bottomed out to \$2-4 per barrel in Q1FY26 GETTY IMAGES/STOCKPHOTO

three fiscal years, marked by sharp fluctuations in GRMs amid rapidly evolving global market dynamics, CareEdge said.

GRMs declined from a high of \$10-12 per barrel in FY24 to \$4-6 per barrel in FY25 and further bottomed out to \$2-4 per barrel in

Q1FY26. This downturn was driven by narrowing discounts on Russian crude oil, weaker product cracks and heightened geopolitical uncertainties, it added.

“GRMs rebounded significantly to \$8-10 per barrel in Q2FY26 and further to \$9-13 per barrel in Q3FY26,

thereby outperforming the Singapore benchmark, supported by agile inventory management, a decline in crude oil prices, healthy product cracks and wider discounts on Russian crude due to US restrictions on Russian crude oil trade,” it pointed out.

A defining theme in the latter half of FY26 is the gradual unwinding of the ‘Russian pivot’, which significantly supported India's refining margins in FY23 and FY24.

India's crude oil procurement profile has shifted — from elevated dependence on Russian crude in FY24 (around 36 per cent) to about 30 per cent in Q3FY26. This is expected to fall further in Q4FY26, it projected.

Dabur names Herjit Bhalla as CEO for India Business

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Herjit S Bhalla, CEO - India Business, Dabur India

Dabur India on Tuesday announced the appointment of Herjit S Bhalla as the Chief Executive Officer-India Business with effect from April 15.

Effective February 17, Mohit Malhotra has been designated as Whole Time Director and Global Chief Executive Officer, the company said in a regulatory filing.

“Appointment of Herjit S Bhalla as Senior Management Personnel of the company with the designation Chief Executive Officer - India Business. Herjit S Bhalla will report to Mohit Mathotra, Whole-time Director and Global Chief Executive Officer of the company,” the BSE filing stated.

VAST EXPERIENCE
Bhalla is currently serving as

Vice-President-Canada and Global Customers, The Hershey Company. “He brings over 25 years of deep commercial and general management experience across diverse geographies and business contexts,” the company added.

In 2018, he joined The Hershey Company as Managing Director for India and since then has held several global roles with the company.

In the past, he held senior level roles in Metro Cash & Carry and Unilever.

Rupee stabilises as dollar lacks momentum

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The rupee remained largely steady last week and closed at 90.68 on Tuesday. The domestic currency traded within a narrow range as opposing factors kept it anchored.



WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

On the negative side, macro data turned less supportive. India's trade deficit widened sharply to \$34.68 billion in January, compared with \$23 billion in the same month last year, pointing to increased dollar demand.

Wholesale price inflation (WPI) also hardened to 1.81 per cent in January from 0.83 per cent in the previous month, adding to concerns

for the local currency. Both these factors are typically unfavourable for the rupee.

However, foreign flows provided a counterbalance. According to NSDL data, net FPI inflows stood at \$881 million over the past week, lending support to the local currency and limiting downside.

On the global front, the dollar remained broadly flat. US inflation eased to 2.4 per cent in January, the lowest since May 2025, strengthen-

ing expectations that the Federal Reserve may have room to cut rates. Such expectations tend to weigh on the dollar, indirectly offering support to emerging market currencies, including the rupee. Overall, despite domestic headwinds, positive flows and a softer dollar bias kept the rupee stable.

further to 91.25. But if it appreciates and breaks out of the barrier at 90.20, the rupee can rise further to 89.80.

If the dollar index also stays flat, it increases the probability for the rupee-dollar exchange rate to stay stable. The index has been trading between the support at 96.60 and the resistance at 97.30. If the barrier at 97.30 is breached, the dollar index can extend the upswing to 98, which can impact the rupee negatively. But if the dollar index slips below 96.60, it can drop to 96. Such a decline can help the rupee in advancing.

OUTLOOK
Overall, with the dollar lacking clear momentum, the rupee may continue to consolidate. In the near term, it is expected to move within the 90.20-90.80 band.

Service bottlenecks weigh on Ola Electric volumes; regional rebound visible, says Bhavish Aggarwal

Our Bureau
Bengaluru



As we improve our service and our sales recover, we will see a faster roadmap to profitability



The sales volume at Ola Electric have declined in recent quarters as service execution gaps dented customer confidence, Chairman and Managing Director Bhavish Aggarwal acknowledged during the company's post-quarter analyst call.

BHAVISH AGGARWAL
Chairman and Managing Director, Ola Electric

He said delays in service accessibility and turnaround times weighed on demand and impacted brand trust. However, he noted that underlying demand remains strong. In markets where service bottlenecks had been resolved more effectively, volumes had rebounded sharply, rising two-three times, indicating that customers return once opera-

tional issues are addressed.

The company is prioritising long-term service reliability and customer confidence over short-term market share gains. Revenue from operations declined to ₹470 crore during Q3 from ₹1,045 crore, while E2W deliveries was at 32,680 units.

HEAVY INVESTMENT
Aggarwal highlighted that

Ola Electric had invested about ₹5,300 crore over the past few years in manufacturing, battery innovation, and research and development, enabling vertical integration across motors, batteries, cells, electronics and software. With capacity now supporting up to one million vehicles annually and 6 GWh of cell production, he said the heavy investment phase

is largely complete and the focus is shifting to scaling utilisation. At full capacity, the installed base offers a revenue potential of ₹15,000-20,000 crore.

Ola Electric expects sales momentum to improve as service metrics stabilise and customer confidence returns. “As we improve our service and our sales recover, we will see a faster roadmap to profitability,” he said.

He added that it may take another quarter to fully institutionalise service processes, noting the company has taken a foundational approach to fixing front-end operational gaps and is already seeing improvements in service delivery and cost structures. Fixing service, he said, will allow the product advantage to shine.

India's data centre boom raises ‘power’ concerns

Rohan Das
Chennai

With policy tailwinds and mega investments from hyperscalers signalling a rapid expansion of India's data centre capacity, the question of power requirements for the energy-hungry industry has come to the fore. Per industry estimates, power for about 30-35 per cent of the current data centre capacity comes from renewable sources, predominantly through power purchase agreements (PPAs).

For instance, Sify Infinet Spaces sources 38 per cent of its total portfolio through renewable PPAs, while Tech-noDigital, the data centre arm of TechnoElectric, has about 85 per cent of its current capacity sourced through renewable PPAs.

centre capacity addition is expected to be about 0.5 GW each year, and investments are going into both grid and green power with grid power addition alone around 5-6 GW per year. So, there should be enough power in the short term.”

He added that while tax provisions and other headwinds might spur an uptick in data centre capacity addition, it might not be enough to create a power deficit. However, he noted that over the longer term, power could be a bottleneck, especially if capacity rises exponentially beyond previous estimates.



trated in a few key metros. This means that data centres are often competing for power with cities that have large populations and high local demand.

Ankit Saraiya, CEO, Technodigital, said that there are locations in India where data centres already consume 15 per cent of total grid capacity, which is bound to reach

30-35 per cent by 2030. “The challenge is not in sourcing renewable or thermal power, but in getting the capacity delivered to your site. Power ultimately flows through the same grid, and the question is whether the network has the transmission and distribution strength to serve additional demand,” he said.

He added that moving the data centres to tier-1 and -2 cities that are closer to the generating station and have much lower grid load could be a solution. The challenge in moving these centres, Lahoti said, would be the availability of fibre connectivity and the talent in these locations.

CAPTIVE ROUTE
Roopesh Kumar, Head-Data Centre Projects, Sify Technologies, said that the company plans to source incremental power through a combination of renewable PPAs and group captive arrangements.

The issue, however, is not restricted to capacity alone, but also to the grid strength needed to deliver power to the centres. According to data from real estate services firm CBRE, over 90 per cent of data centres are concen-

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SUPPLY COMFORT
Abhishek Lahoti, Assistant Vice-President and Sector Head, ICRA, said that at the current rate of annual capacity addition, energy requirements can be met organically through a combination of green and grid power. “Data

HomeRun raises ₹60 crore Series A funding

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Bengaluru-based quick commerce platform HomeRun has raised ₹60 crore in a Series A round led by Sorin Investments, which invested ₹40 crore.

The rest came largely from Titan Capital Winners Fund, led by Kunal Bahl and Rohit Bansal. Sparrow Capital, Consumer Collective by Atrium and Helios Holdings also participated.

HomeRun said the funds will be used to expand product categories and scale its dark-store network. The company will also invest in direct sourcing, supply chain operations and technology.

With inputs from intern Tejaswin S

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No: KCB/72/100/2026/IVC(18) **Date: 17.02.2026**
E-Tender Notice
Kerala Cashew Board Limited invites e-tenders through e-procurement portal for the import of 2000-5000 Metric Tonnes of quality **Dried Raw Cashew Nut of 2026 crop of Cote D'Ivoire origin**, with the following quality specifications on import basis. (Tender ID:- 2026_KCBL_837098_1)
Outturn : 48 lbs. per 80 Kg bag
Nut Count : 190 Numbers per Kg
Last date for submission and uploading e-tenders : 1700 hours on 17th March 2026
Opening of e-tender : 1100 hours on 18th March 2026
All details can be viewed, downloaded and applied through the e-procurement portal www.etenders.kerala.gov.in
CHAIRMAN & MANAGING DIRECTOR

THE RAMARAJU SURGICAL COTTON MILLS LIMITED
Regd. Off.: 119, P.A.C. Ramasamy Raja Salai, Rajapalayam - 626117.
Ph.: 04562-235904 | E-Mail: rscm@ramcotex.com
CIN : L17111TN1939PLC002302 | Website : www.ramarajusurgical.com
NOTICE OF POSTAL BALLOT / E-VOTING
[Pursuant to Section 110 of the Companies Act, 2013, Rule 22 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 and Regulation 44 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015]
Dear Members,
Members are hereby informed that, pursuant to the provisions of Sections 108, 110 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Companies Act, 2013, as amended ("the Act") read with Rules 20 and 22 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, ("the Rules"), read with the General Circulars issued earlier in this regard by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA"), Secretarial Standards - 2 on General Meetings issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India and, applicable provisions of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("the LODR") and pursuant to other applicable laws, rules and regulations, approval of the members of the Company (as on the Cut-off Date viz Friday, the 13th February, 2026) ("Members" or "Equity Shareholders"), is sought through Postal Ballot, only by way of E-Voting to transact the herein below mentioned Special Businesses, as set-forth in the Notice dated 12th February, 2026:

No.	Agenda of the Notice	Resolution
1.	Reappointment of Shri P.A.S. Alaghar Raja (DIN: 00487312) as an Independent Director	Special Resolution
2.	Approval of Sale of Investments to Rajapalayam Mills Limited, a related party	Ordinary Resolution
3.	Approval of Sale of Investments to Sri Vishnu Shankar Mills Limited, a related party	Ordinary Resolution

The Company has engaged the services of Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL"), for providing e-voting facility to the members of the Company. The detailed procedure to cast the vote forms part of the "Notes" section of the Notice.
The e-voting facility will be available during the following period:

Commencement of e-voting period	9.00 a.m. IST on Wednesday, February 18, 2026
Conclusion of e-voting period	5.00 p.m. IST on Friday, March 20, 2026
Cut-off date for eligibility to vote	Friday, February 13, 2026

The e-voting facility will be disabled by CDSL immediately after 5.00 p.m. IST on Friday, March 20, 2026, and will be disallowed thereafter.
Members who have not updated their e-mail address are requested to register the same in respect of the shares held by them in electronic form with their respective Depository participants and in respect of the shares held in physical form with the Company. Members who have not received this notice due to non-registration of their e-mail addresses with the company/depositories, are also entitled to e-vote in relation to the resolution as set out in this notice.
Members may note that Notice will also be available on the Company at www.ramarajusurgical.com, on website of the Stock Exchange i.e. Metropolitan Stock Exchange of India Limited (MSEI) at www.msei.in and the website of CDSL at www.evotingindia.com.
The results of this postal ballot along with the Scrutinizer's Report will be filed with MSEI and CDSL within the Statutory timelines and will also be hosted in the Company's website.
All grievances connected with the facility for voting by electronic means may be addressed to Mr. Rakesh Dalvi, Sr. Manager, Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futrex, Mafatlal Mill Compounds, N M Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai - 400013 or send an email to helpdesk.evoting@cdsindia.com or call toll free no. 1800 21 09911.
For THE RAMARAJU SURGICAL COTTON MILLS LIMITED Sd/-
Rajapalayam P. Muthukumar
17.02.2026 Company Secretary & Compliance Officer
Mem. No. F12904

भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक
RESERVE BANK OF INDIA
www.rbi.org.in
RECRUITMENT OF ASSISTANT - 2025
Reserve Bank of India invites applications from eligible candidates for the post of Assistant (650 posts) in various offices of the Bank. Selection for the post will be through a country-wide centre-wise competitive two phase Online Examination and Language Proficiency Test. The full text of advertisement will be available on the Bank's website (www.rbi.org.in) in the third week of February 2026 and is also being published in Employment News/ Rozgar Samachar. Applications will be accepted only online through the Bank's website.
Important Dates:

Application Submission Window and Payment of Examination Fees Online	February 16, 2026 - March 08, 2026
Date of Preliminary Online Examination (Tentative)	April 11, 2026
Date of Main Online Examination (Tentative)	June 07, 2026

"Don't get cheated by E-mails/ SMSs/ Calls promising you money"

COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LIMITED
CIAL/CIVIL/705 18.02.2026
TENDER NOTICE
Item rate E-tenders are invited from reputed civil contractors for the work mentioned below at Cochin International Airport, Nedumbassery.

Name of Work	Estimated Amount (Rs.)	EMD	Period of Completion
Revamping of Club House and Academy Building at CIAL Golf Club	6.83 Crores	Rs.10,00,000/- through online payment	12 months

For more details visit our website www.cial.aero Sd/-
MANAGING DIRECTOR

COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LIMITED
CIAL/ELE/A36/ET17 18.02.2026
TENDER NOTICE
Item rate E-tenders are invited for the below-mentioned works from reputed firms.

Name of Work	Estimated Amount (Rs.)	EMD (Rs.)	Tender ID
Electromechanical works for Augmentation of STP at CIAL	185 Lakhs	4 Lakhs	2026_CIAL_83319_1

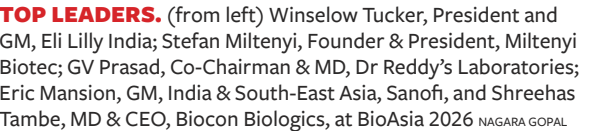
For further details visit the website <https://www.cial.aero/tenders>. Interested agencies may register themselves on the online E-Tendering portal <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> and can download the tender documents. Sd/-
Managing Director

Agency for New and Renewable Energy Research and Technology (ANERT)
Vikas Bhavan PO, Thiruvananthapuram - 695033, Kerala
Department of Power, Government of Kerala, State Nodal Agency, Ministry of New and Renewable Energy, Govt. of India
Tender Reference no: ANERT-TVM/57/2025-DE(TVM)
Tender ID: 2026_ANERT_827461_1
Call for Registration of Vendors of Solar Power Plants
Competitive e-tenders in one cover system with Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) are invited from reputed Manufacturers/System Integrators / EPC Contractors with relevant experience in the Expression of Interest (EOI) for Registration of Vendor for Installation of Solar Projects in the State of Kerala. The e-tender documents can be downloaded from the e-tendering website of Govt. of Kerala. www.etenders.kerala.gov.in.
Last date for submission of bids: 28 February 2026 Sd/-
CEO

Bangalore: Energy-tech company Exponent Energy on Tuesday announced the launch of Exponent One, a fintech and asset management venture focused on commercial electric vehicles. It will be led by CEO and Co-Founder Sandeep Divakaran. Exponent One will operate as a 360-degree underwriting and asset-management platform for commercial EVs. It will focus on three- and four-wheelers, light commercial vehicles, buses and trucks. The firm said the venture aims to address a barrier to commercial EV adoption, i.e., access to financing. It has raised \$2 million in pre-seed funding. The funds will support early rollout and expansion across commercial EV hubs. OUR BUREAU

"India did become the generic pharma hub of the world, while value lies in innovation and volume lies in generics. There may not be any significant shift in product portfolio in the next five years, but growth can now be seen in biologicals and services," said GV

Five years from now would be "too soon" to witness big shifts in the industry, he said, adding, "But

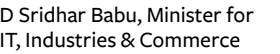


Key requirements for the next phase of growth are: Differential pricing, innovation, a technology-enabled ecosystem with robust application of augmented intel-

ligence would be vital going forward, according to Winslow Tucker, President and GM, Eli Lilly and Company (India). From a regulatory point of view, a different policy shift was needed with provisions to reward break-

Even though there are risks, Biocon had an innovation-led culture, said Tambe. "We took bets which are not conventional," he said, adding the outcome of R&D investments would decide the investor perception.

Advanced technologies like artificial intelligence



(AI) should be harnessed by the life sciences industry in drug discovery and innovation, he said.

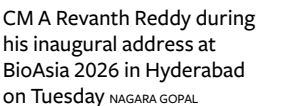
SKILLS

To ensure adequate supply of skilled professionals, a new life sciences university is being established, the Minister said. It would offer advanced training in emerging fields like AI-driven drug discovery, automation, among others, he added.

The Telangana School of Life Sciences and Young India Skills University would help create industry-ready workforce, Sridhar Babu said.

Telangana is offering a stable and reliable ecosystem for the development of life sciences. It has already become a hub of Global Capability Centres (GCCs).

The State will play a key role in convergence of pharma/biology and technology, he added.



K Satish Reddy, Chairman, Dr Reddy's Laboratories, said there was a pro-

There are over 800 pharma/life sciences firms in Hyderabad with about 250 USFDA approved plants and 40 per cent of the country's total production of Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients (APIs) come from Telangana, Reddy said.

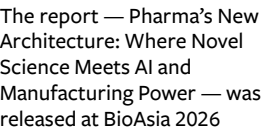
“We are creating new clusters. In the last two calendar years, 40 per cent of GCCs of the country came to Hyderabad totalling to 150. We will cross 100 new GCCs in the present calendar year of 2026,” he said.

INVESTMENTS

The inaugural address saw announcements on investments made by Opella

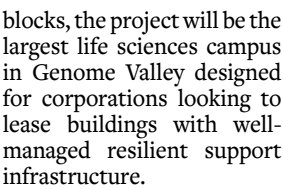
The two-day conference is being attended by industry representatives and scientists from across the world with plenary sessions on a range of topics spanning across of R&D and convergence of technology.

“The shift from one-off products to reusable engines — from mRNA and CRISPR to AI-driven design stacks — is redefining speed,



At present, the H125 is the most widely used helicopter in India and South Asia.

Planned as a single, integrated campus with multiple



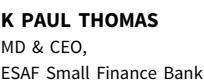
blocks, the project will be the largest life sciences campus in Genome Valley designed for corporations looking to lease buildings with well-managed resilient support infrastructure.

The campus will cater to Indian and global life sciences companies seeking scalable and quality infrastructure for R&D and allied operations, delivering institutional-grade laboratory spaces, bringing together

Pocket FM's data show a shift in income distribution within the creator ecosystem. More than 20 per cent of creators are now earning over ₹1 lakh per month, while the top 1 per cent make upwards of ₹50 lakh annually. Collectively, the top 10 per cent of monetised creat-

Founder and CEO. In 2025, several Hindi-language titles were localised for audiences in the US and Europe. Pocket FM currently generates over 2.2 billion minutes of listening every month.

Your portfolio mix is shifting from unsecured to secured loans...



loans. Retail advances include vehicle loans, home loans, affordable housing and loan against property. We are not moving away

Even gold loans are very competitive, especially in the Southern region; PSU banks are very aggressive on gold loans. But it is the about customer service and relations that matter. We hold around

The success of the microfinance industry was based on strong engagement with the local community. So, we are trying to bring that back. We have got dedicated community engagement teams that arrange various productive activities.

As of now, we are not eligible. We don't meet required bad loan ratios, and two annual years complete profitability parameters. We could consider after two years.

TN ‘on a fiscal consolidation path’

INTERIM BUDGET. Fiscal deficit pegged at 3% of GSDP in FY27; capex at ₹59,561 crore, an increase of 15.78% from FY26

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu has reiterated its commitment to fiscal consolidation, with the fiscal deficit in the interim budget estimates for 2026-27 projected to decline to 3 per cent of the GSDP (3.45 per cent in the previous fiscal), Finance Minister Thangam Thennarasu said.

Despite multiple challenges on the economic and fiscal fronts, the Minister said the State had charted a clear medium-term consolidation path.

The fiscal deficit-to-GSDP ratio is projected to decline further to 2.89 per cent in 2027-28 and 2.8 per cent in 2028-29, remaining within the limits prescribed under the Tamil Nadu Fiscal Responsibility Act, 2003.

The revenue deficit in the interim budget estimates for 2026-27 is estimated at ₹48,696 crore. With a series of revenue augmentation measures, including improvements in tax administration and collection efficiency, it is expected to decline to ₹42,964 crore in 2027-28 and further to

₹35,115 crore in 2028-29. The reduction is expected to create additional fiscal space for higher capital expenditure in the coming years, he said.

On borrowings, the estimates for receipts and repayments had been finalised in line with the overall borrowing ceiling fixed by the Centre. The State plans to borrow ₹1.79 lakh crore during 2026-27 and repay ₹60,413 crore. As a result, the outstanding borrowing as on March 31, 2027, is projected at ₹10.71 lakh crore, which is equivalent to 26.35 per cent of the GSDP, he said.

The figure includes ₹9,522 crore related to the Chennai Metro Rail Phase-II, which is yet to be reflected in the accounts of the Centre following its approval as a Central project. Excluding this amount, the outstanding debt-to-GSDP ratio is estimated at 26.12 per cent in 2026-27.

The ratio is projected to decline further to 25.8 per cent in 2027-28 and 25.43 per cent in 2028-29, highlighting the State's focus on debt sustainability, he said.

Capital expenditure (capex) allocation will be



POLL PITCH. Tamil Nadu Finance Minister Thangam Thennarasu presenting the interim Budget for financial year 2026-27 at the Assembly in Chennai on Tuesday

₹59,561 crore, an increase of 15.78 per cent over ₹51,442 crore in the revised estimates for 2025-26. Capex is projected to rise to ₹74,452 crore in 2027-28 and ₹93,065 crore in 2028-29, he said.

Net loans and advances are estimated at ₹13,708 crore in 2026-27 and projected to increase to ₹16,449 crore in 2027-28 and ₹19,739 crore in 2028-29, mainly due to new metro rail projects announced by the government.

The State's own tax revenue (SOTR) is estimated at ₹2.06 lakh crore in the revised estimates for 2025-26

and is projected to rise to ₹2.29 lakh crore in the interim budget estimates for 2026-27. The projections factor in improved economic activity, including the positive impact of trade deals with the US and the European Union, even as GST rate rationalisation in the previous year had an adverse effect.

SOTR is expected to grow to ₹2.61 lakh crore in 2027-28 and ₹2.98 lakh crore in 2028-29, with a growth rate of 14 per cent in both years, he said.

The Minister added that Tamil Nadu's growth continues to outpace the national

GDP growth, and the State will continue to strengthen revenue mobilisation while adhering to the fiscal responsibility norms to support growth and welfare spending.

“Despite numerous obstacles caused by the step-motherly treatment of the Union government, including denial of funds and withholding of welfare schemes, the State continues to achieve remarkable milestones,” he said.

The 16th Finance Commission had recently submitted its report and the action taken report was placed by the Union government in Parliament on February 1. The 16th Finance Commission's report has been a great disappointment to Tamil Nadu, he said.

valent to approximately 33 per cent of the outstanding debt, he said.

In the 16th Finance Commission, while Kerala and Karnataka had been given a growth of 23.74 per cent and 13.27 per cent respectively, Tamil Nadu had been given a marginal increase of 0.44 per cent, the lowest among comparable States, he added.

The State's overall outstanding debt is estimated to be ₹9.52 lakh crore in the revised estimates for 2025-26 as against ₹9.29 lakh crore in the budget estimates for 2025-26. However, this includes an amount of ₹9,523 crore which should reflect in the accounts of the Union government after the approval of Chennai Metro Rail Phase II as a Central project, he said.

The outstanding debt to GSDP ratio (excluding debt for Chennai Metro Rail Phase II) in the revised estimates 2025-26 is estimated to marginally increase to 26.43 per cent as compared to 26.39 per cent in the accounts of 2024-25. In the interim budget estimates for 2026-27, this ratio is expected to decrease to 26.12 per cent, he said.

State all set to unveil agroforestry policy

Our Bureau
Chennai

The Tamil Nadu Agroforestry Policy will be released shortly to enable farmers to cultivate high-value trees such as teak, sandalwood, red sanders and mahogany. The policy provides for relaxation of rules on felling and transportation of felled trees, provision of necessary assistance for planting and maintenance, and formulation and implementation of schemes to promote agroforestry, State Minister for Agriculture & Farmers Welfare MRK Paneerselvam announced in the agriculture interim budget 2026-27.

To increase the production and consumption of millets, the Tamil Nadu Millet Mission is being implemented as a five-year scheme from 2023-24. So far, 12.84 lakh farmers had benefited, with an expenditure of ₹178 crore. To ensure timely farming and to address the shortage of labourers, a total of 77,499 agricultural machinery and implements have been provided to farmers; 1,320 custom hiring centres were established.



Subsidies of ₹783 crore were sanctioned in the past five years, he said. To ensure uninterrupted irrigation power supply through renewable energy, 4,150 solar-powered pump sets were installed, with a subsidy of ₹83 crore. The Minister said two lakh free electricity connections were provided. The government sanctioned ₹33,904 crore towards meeting the cost of providing free electricity to 23.86 lakh agricultural connections.

REGULATED MARKETS
An additional 150 regulated markets had been integrated with the e-National Agriculture Market (eNAM). Around 30 lakh metric tonnes (mt) of agricultural produce, valued at ₹8,748 crore, had been transacted through this platform, benefiting 18 lakh farmers.

‘Banks must not levy penalty for failure to maintain minimum balance in SB a/cs’

K Ram Kumar
Mumbai

Banks should adopt a “positive reinforcement approach” to encourage customers to maintain higher balances in savings bank (SB) accounts instead of penalising them for not maintaining minimum balance, according to a parliamentary committee.

The committee on petitions recommended that public sector banks (PSBs) and private sector banks (PvSBs) encourage accumulation of higher balances through incentives such as reward points, fee waivers and higher interest rate for customers maintaining consistent deposits.

The panel is of the view that this positive reinforcement approach is more compatible with financial inclusion.

After carefully evaluating the fine balance between the autonomy given to banks and the interest of account holders, especially those belonging to the economically vulnerable sections, the committee proposed that all banks, whether in the private or public sector, should adopt a uniform policy of not charging penalties for failure to maintain minimum balance in all regular savings bank accounts.

In this regard, the Department of Financial Services (DFS) and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) may consider issuing necessary guidelines to all banks.

SBI LEADS WAY
The panel highlighted the case of the State Bank of India (SBI), which was the first among the major PSBs to waive charges for non-maintenance of minimum balance with effect from March 11, 2020.

In its reply to the committee, SBI stated: “MAB (monthly average balance) charges were waived to improve customer service standard, to encourage saving habit among small customers and incentivise customers to stay with SBI.”

While the aforementioned move impacted short-term profitability, it has been beneficial for the bank in the long-run by improving customer satisfaction, thereby attracting more customers and potentially increasing overall business.

The committee noted that SBI offset the loss of revenue on account of waiver of charges for non-maintenance of minimum balance in SB accounts through cost reduction via digital push and migrating customers to digital channels, acquiring more customers and increasing business level. SBI's rev-

enue almost doubled, and net profit increased more than three times since 2020.

Following SBI's footsteps, most of the PSBs, including Canara Bank, Punjab National Bank, Bank of India, Union Bank of India, Central Bank of India and Bank of Baroda, have waived charges for non-maintenance of minimum balance in all kinds of savings accounts.

According to information provided by the Department of Financial Services to the committee, the remaining PSBs are exploring the possibility of removing the penalty.

FOR SMALL BIZ
The committee suggested that all PSBs and PvSBs may consider the feasibility of offering a customised current account product, especially for the use of small entrepreneurs.

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu is set to release a dedicated shipbuilding policy to promote investments in shipbuilding and marine ancillary manufacturing, State Finance and Environment Minister Thangam Thennarasu announced while presenting the interim budget estimates for 2026-27 in the Assembly on Tuesday.

NEW CLUSTER
Positioning itself as an emerging global hub for shipbuilding, the State will establish a shipbuilding cluster at Thoothukudi at an estimated cost of ₹5,200 crore.

The project will be implemented through a special purpose vehicle by SIPCOT, in association with the VO Chidambaranar Port Authority.

An MoU has been signed with leading shipbuilding companies, including Union

government public sector undertakings and a major global shipbuilder, involving investment commitments of around ₹30,000 crore, the Minister said.

INDUSTRY & MSMEs
An allocation of ₹4,282 crore had been made for the Industries, Investment Promotion and Commerce Department, while ₹1,943 crore had been earmarked for the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Department.

Tamil Nadu, home to over 40 lakh registered MSMEs, has seen ₹10.70 lakh crore in bank credit disbursed to the sector over the past five years. During this period, TANSIDCO developed 18 industrial estates, creating 3,735 jobs.

To ensure timely payments to MSMEs, the TN TReDS platform has facilitated transactions worth ₹5,171 crore, benefiting 1,461 enterprises so far, he said.

The Ministry stated that

an integrated renewable energy policy is set to be released soon to enhance renewable energy capacity in the State. An allocation of ₹18,091 crore has been made for the Energy Department.

CHIP MISSION
The Tamil Nadu Semiconductor Mission – 2030, a five-year roadmap with an outlay of ₹500 crore, is under implementation. Works are underway at Taramani, Chennai, to establish a Centre for Advanced Semiconductor

Technologies in collaboration with the Indian Institute of Technology-Madras, along with a Centre of Excellence for semiconductor design and testing.

The Information Technology and Digital Services Department has been allocated ₹219 crore.

SUMMER PACKAGE
Under the *Magalir Urimai Thittam*, ₹5,000 (₹3,000 entitlement for February-April and a ₹2,000 summer special package) was credited directly to the bank accounts of 1.31 crore women beneficiaries. Around ₹6,500 crore was disbursed across the State in a single day, Thennarasu said. From April 2025, registration fee for immovable properties valued up to ₹10 lakh and registered in the name of women were reduced by 1 per cent, benefiting 3.71 lakh women so far.

HOUSE-SITE PATTAS
Over the past five years, 23.56 lakh house site *pattas* had been issued. Under the

One-Time Special Regularisation Scheme, 77,800 online *pattas* had been granted to families residing on unobjectionable government *poramboke* lands, including 15,393 in Chennai and adjoining areas.

Land resurvey work using Real Time Kinematics technology is underway in Krishnagiri, The Nilgiris and Kanyakumari districts.

The School Education Department has been given ₹48,534 crore in the interim budget, he said.

**Karnataka Bank**
Regd. & Head Office: Mangaluru - 575 002 CIN: L85110KA1924PLC001128 E-mail: info@kbbank.com Visit us at: https://karnatakabank.bank.in

102nd Founders' Day Celebration

Today
18th February 2026, Wednesday 4.00 pm

Venue: Karnataka Bank Auditorium, 4th Floor, Head Office Building
Mahaveera Circle, Kankanady, Mangaluru - 575 002



LECTURE by
Shri Debasish Panda,
IAS (Retd.)
Visionary Bureaucrat | Policy Reformer |
Technology Enthusiast



Shri Raghavendra S Bhat
Managing Director & CEO, Karnataka Bank

The programme is followed by

All-Women Classical Music Ensemble Concert



Vidushi
Manasi Prasad
Vocal



Vidushi
Sukanya Ramgopal
Ghatam Tarang



Vidushi
C V Shruti
Violin



Vidushi
Y G Srilatha Nikshith
Veena



Vidushi
Ranjani Siddhanti Venkatesh
Mridangam



Vidushi
Bhagyalakshmi Krishna
Morsing

Follow us on :      / KarnatakaBank

Enterprise Connect

Business Initiative

SBI Bhopal organised Health Awareness Camp at Bhopal:



State Bank of India, successfully organized a grand Health Awareness Camp at its Local Head Office today under the Corporate Employee Engagement initiative, with the objective of strengthening employees' health, energy, and work efficiency. The programme was formally inaugurated by the Circle Head and Chief General Manager, Shri Pravash Kumar Subudhi, General Manager-II Shri Omkarnath Choudhary, General Manager-III Shri Manoj Kumar, and DGM & CDO Shri Manish Mathpal by undergoing their own health check-ups, setting an inspiring example for all. A large number of officers and staff members from the Local Head Office participated in the camp with great enthusiasm and discipline. The camp included various medical examinations such as blood pressure, blood sugar, ECG, and eye check-ups, along with personalized consultations by experienced medical professionals. Addressing the gathering, Chief General Manager Shri Pravash Kumar Subudhi said, "A healthy body and positive mindset are the keys to excellent performance. When we take care of our health, the organization continues to progress steadily." He encouraged all employees to undergo regular health check-ups and adopt a balanced and healthy lifestyle. This initiative reflects the State Bank of India's strong commitment towards employee welfare, proving that the Bank considers its human resources as its greatest asset and continuously strives for their development and well-being.

Department of IT, DNH & DD Organises Pre-Event Workshop for India AI Impact Summit 2026

The Department of Information Technology, Union Territory of Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu, in collaboration with the National e-Governance Division (NeGD) and the State e-Mission Team (SeMT), organised a Pre-Event Workshop for the India AI Impact Summit 2026 at the NIFT/GEC Seminar Hall, Varkund, Nani Daman on Feb 9th 2026. The workshop, themed "Building Inclusive Futures: Regional Growth under Digital India and the IndiaAI Mission," aimed at enhancing awareness and capacity building on the application of Artificial Intelligence across governance, education, industry, healthcare, and community development, in alignment with the vision of the Hon'ble Prime Minister of India. The programme began with a welcome address by Shri Amit Kumar Parnasi, DANICS, Director-cum-JS (IT), who stated that the initiative is being implemented under the guidance of the Hon'ble Administrator, Shri Praful Patel, to accelerate digital transformation and promote innovation in the Union Territory. Shri Ajay Kumar Gupta, IAS, Secretary (IT), joined the workshop during the second session and emphasised that such initiatives are vital for strengthening institutional preparedness and aligning regional efforts with national digital priorities under the IndiaAI Mission. Delivering keynote insights, Shri Nikhil U. Dessai, IAS, Secretary (Transport), highlighted the role of Artificial Intelligence and emerging technologies in improving governance efficiency, enabling data-driven decision-making, and enhancing citizen-centric service delivery through responsible AI adoption. Shri Kishore Choudhary, Director, NIELIT, emphasised the importance of AI skill development for building a future-ready workforce, while Shri Paresh Gajjar, Organising Secretary, Silvassa Industry Federation Association, highlighted AI-driven industrial automation and the need for strengthened industry-government collaboration. The workshop witnessed participation from over 265 stakeholders offline and around 50 online, including government officers, academicians, and technical professionals.

CHRIST UNIVERSITY launches New course at Pune - Lavasa campus

In response to the rapidly evolving global financial landscape, CHRIST (Deemed to be University), Pune Lavasa campus, has launched an innovative undergraduate programme, BCom in Financial Analytics. Developed in collaboration with NSE Academy, the four-year course aligns with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, offering flexible pathways for Honours and Research specialisations. Breaking away from traditional commerce education, the programme prioritises industry-relevant skills such as Algorithmic Trading, FinTech, and Machine Learning. It integrates professional certifications within the curriculum, enabling students to graduate with both academic and industry-recognised credentials. Focusing on tool-based learning, students gain hands-on expertise in Python and R for analysing complex financial data. With simulations and compulsory internships, the programme seeks to bridge the gap between academic knowledge and real-world financial practices.

Goa Showcases Wellness Tourism Vision at the 3rd Edition of the International Ayush Conference & Exhibition



The 3rd edition of International Ayush Conference and Publicity was inaugurated at the hands of Shri Prataprao Jadhav, Union Minister of State(C), Ministry of Ayush, Govt of India, New Delhi in the August presence of Shri Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha, Secretary, Ministry of Ayush, Govt; Dr. Deepak Mittal, Ambassador of India, United Arab Emirates and H. E. Dr. Alawi Alsheikh Al Director General Dubai Health Authority amongst others. H. E. Dr. Alawi Alsheikh Al Director General Dubai Health Authority during his visit to the stall evincing keen interest in the activities complemented the Government of Goa for effectively displaying the various activities being undertaken in the Ayush and Allied Sector. Shri Dipak Bandekar, Director, DIP speaking informally after inaugurating the State Pavilion said "Goa's participation at the Exhibition marks a significant step in positioning the State as a global wellness destination. The platform brought together leading practitioners, policymakers, and industry stakeholders in Ayurveda and other traditional systems of AYUSH, enabling meaningful dialogue and collaboration. For Goa, this was not merely an exhibition, but a strategic engagement to showcase our growing wellness ecosystem and reinforce Ayurveda as a key pillar of our tourism diversification strategy. The encouraging response we received reflects the growing international interest in authentic and sustainable wellness experiences."

IIT Bhubaneswar released a study on the transformation journey of Tata Power led Central Odisha Discom's power distribution reforms.



The Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Bhubaneswar has released a study on the power distribution performance of TP Central Odisha Distribution Limited (TPCODL), a joint venture of Tata Power and Government of Odisha, examining how network reliability, operational efficiency, technological interventions and customer service delivery have evolved over a five-year period following distribution sector reforms. The study evaluates the outcomes of sustained capital investment, network modernisation and the progressive adoption of digital technologies in the distribution network. The study has been prepared by Prof. Chandrasekhar Bhende (Professor), Dr. Chandrasekhar Perumalla (Associate Professor) and Dr. Abhinnet Prakash (Assistant Professor) from the Department of Electrical Engineering, School of Electrical & Computer Sciences, IIT Bhubaneswar. It assesses the performance of TPCODL, which serves a populace of 1.36 crore across 29,354 sq. km in Central Odisha. The analysis is based on field inspections, validation of system data and a review of operational and consumer service practices across both urban and rural areas. A key observation of the study is a significant reduction in outage duration, reflected in an improvement of approximately 50% in the System Average Interruption Duration Index (SAIDI) over the review period. This improvement indicates a more stable and resilient distribution network supported by enhanced fault detection, faster fault isolation and improved restoration processes, which have also contributed to a reduction in transformer tripping rates and transformer failure rates. The study also records notable progress in operational efficiency, with Aggregate Technical and Commercial (AT&C) losses declining from around 30% at the start of the reform period to 18.94% in FY25. This improvement has been driven by better operational control, improved billing processes and enhanced network efficiency, supported by a 44% addition in 33 kV feeders, a 42% addition in 11 kV feeders and the integration of 250 substations into a centralised control centre. Over the five-year period, capital investments exceeding ₹1,500 crore have been directed towards strengthening substations, expanding automation coverage, deploying digital monitoring platforms and enhancing overall network resilience.





A CH-CE

QUICKLY.

Crude oil dips on progress in Iran-US nuclear talks



Crude oil edged lower on signs that the US and Iran have made progress in nuclear talks, eroding a risk premium in benchmark futures prices. West Texas Intermediate fell to trade below \$63 a barrel while Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said that the two countries had “serious, constructive” talks and reached a general agreement on a set of principles. **BLOOMBERG**

Copper falls as inventories rise to 11-month high

London: Copper prices fell on Tuesday as rising inventories in LME-registered warehouses pressured the market, although thin trading volumes amid the Chinese Lunar New Year holiday limited activity. Benchmark 3-month copper on the LME was down 0.8 per cent at \$12,744 a tonne by 0959 GMT. **REUTERS**

Palm oil slides on weak export data



Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures slipped on Monday, ahead of the Lunar New Year holidays that start from Tuesday, pressured by sluggish early February export data and expectations of an accelerated harvest. The benchmark palm oil contract for May delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange fell 32 ringgit to 4,014 ringgit (\$1,029.76) a tonne at the close. **REUTERS**

‘Need to import pulses to meet domestic demand’

AGRI MINISTER SPEAKS. Says India is not self-sufficient in pulses as offtake is higher than output; justifies sops for apple, cotton

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Tuesday said the country will have to import pulses to meet domestic demand as its production not sufficient. Addressing a gathering in Jaipur after launching a farmers helpline under the Bharat-VISTAAR scheme, he said, “Whatever we produce like wheat, rice or maize will not come (from the US). This has been specifically decided so that Indian farmers do not face any loss. But those products which we need, we have to buy from outside... We all know that in case of pulses we are not self sufficient today; consumption is higher than production. It is required to be im-

ported to meet demand. Whatever product we require (to import), why there is objection if it comes from any country?”

RECORD IMPORTS

Chouhan’s statement comes in view of India being the highest producer, consumer and importer of pulses. In the 2024-25 financial year, pulses imports surged to a record high of over 7 million tonnes, valued at over \$5 billion.

This increase was driven by higher imports of tur (pigeon pea) and chickpea (chana) and duty-free imports of yellow peas to meet domestic shortages.

The high imports led to the government imposing a 10 per cent duty on masoor (lentils) from April 1, 2025, and 30 per cent Customs



SLAMS CONGRESS. Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan criticised Rahul Gandhi for opposing imports under the US trade deal.

duty on imports of chana.

From November 1, it imposed a 30 per cent import duty on yellow peas as domestic prices of pulses crashed below the minimum support prices.

During the current fiscal, traders said that pulses imports are likely to drop by at

least 30 per cent to around 4.5 million tonnes. Imports are likely to be lower on higher domestic output of pulses and carryforward stocks. Kharif pulses production has been estimated at 7.41 million tonnes compared with 6.95 million tonnes a year ago.

Centre launches AI-based ‘Bharat VISTAAR’ for farmers

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

The government on Tuesday said that over the next six months, farmers would be able to get guidance and solutions for their problems relating to agriculture from artificial intelligence (AI) technology by a helpline number from a registered mobile phone.

Details of their data like land size, crops grown and fertilizers bought will be available and it will be accessed by the system automatically when it is accessed from a registered mobile phone, and accordingly queries will be answered.

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan inaugurated the ‘Bharat VISTAAR’ scheme, unveiled the farmer-centric AI Hackathon and the Agri Kosh AI Strategy Roadmap at an

event in Jaipur. ‘Bharat VISTAAR’ was announced in the Budget speech by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on February 1.

Terming the Artificial Intelligence-based Bharat-VISTAAR launch as the first stage, Agriculture Secretary Devesh Chaturvedi said it would be connected with Agristack, where all data are getting stored from a farmer identity card.

WHY THIS NOW?

He said “We moved away from bureaucratic red-tapism and reached digital red-tapism” as every department, ministry and even every section within a Ministry are providing information about schemes through different apps and systems.

A farmer who wanted to obtain any information had to go to different apps, and many a times he did not understand which app to use

Farmers can get solutions for their agriculture-related problems by calling helpline number 155261 from a registered phone

for which information, he said, explaining why ‘Bharat VISTAAR’ was created.

Highlighting that an estimated 80 per cent of families in rural areas have at least one smartphone, he said farmers even can call from a keypad mobile phone by dialling the helpline 155261 free of cost.

Currently, Bharat VISTAAR has been launched in Hindi and English, but gradually, it will cover all regional languages, he said, adding the target is to cover additional nine languages in the next six months.



FIRST STAGE. Rajasthan CM Bhajanlal Sharma, Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan and others during the launch of Bharat VISTAAR in Jaipur on Tuesday.

Bharat VISTAAR provides information on *mandi* rates, weather, various central schemes, application status of farmers under any scheme, and ‘Package of Practices’ developed by ICAR scientists. It can be

Taking on the Congress for opposing the US trade deal, Chouhan wondered why it was opposing the import of pulses, cotton and apples if those are needed in the country.

He alleged that some decisions were taken during the Congress’ regime to allow the import of these commodities at higher prices and exports at lower rates.

APPLES AND COTTON

Pointing out that India currently imports 5.5 lakh tonnes of apples annually, mainly from Turkey and Iran, he said: “If 1 lakh tonnes come from America, what will we lose? Why order from Turkey, which opposed us during Operation Sindoor? Let’s order from America.”

He wondered what the issue was if apples were impor-

ted from one country instead of another. Only a small quota with a (minimum) import price of ₹80 per kg and 25 per cent duty would be allowed. “By the time it reaches Jaipur, it will sell at ₹150 per kg. So, what loss is there to our apples?” he asked.

Stressing that these decisions (on farm products) had been made after much thought, Chouhan also said no concession had been given on soybean and maize.

He said the government had decided that milk, ghee, curd, paneer or any dairy product will not be allowed on Indian soil from outside so that Indian milk-producing farmers never face a loss. With regard to cotton, he said that the domestic production was falling short of the cotton industry’s demand.

located, what crop is grown, and others. Within six months, we will link it with AgriStack; after that, as soon as one calls, the system will know from the mobile number where he lives, in which village the field is located, and what are grown in that field,” he said.

“This will bring a revolutionary change in our agricultural extension, which will be very effective in increasing farmers’ income,” Chaturvedi said.

Chouhan said that currently schemes like Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana and Soil Health Card had been included in this initiative, and information about all schemes for farmers will be available through it in the future.

“Preparations are underway to connect the entire agricultural system with the Bharat VISTAAR scheme,” he added.

Cotton imports touch \$1.79 b in April-January

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

India’s imports of raw cotton and waste surged by 72 per cent in dollar terms to over \$1.79 billion during the April-January period of the current financial year as mills and the trade, taking advantage of the duty exemption, made record purchases overseas. Imports of cotton raw and waste were \$1.04 billion a year ago.

As per the latest quick estimates released by the Commerce Ministry, cotton imports in rupee value stood at ₹15,857 crore in the April-January period of FY26, an increase of 81 per cent over corresponding last year’s ₹8771.96 crore. The import value of cotton during FY25 stood at \$1.21 billion, while the previous high during any financial year was \$1.43 billion in 2022-23.

As per Cotton Association



HIGHEST EVER. The cotton imports in rupee value stood at ₹15,857 crore during the April-January period

of India data, about 35 lakh bales of 170 kg each are estimated to have been imported till January-end 2026 in the ongoing cotton year 2025-26, starting October.

In August, the government exempted cotton from import duty till September end initially and extended the duty-free status till December 31, 2025, to augment supplies and ease the burden of the textiles industry, which had come under severe pressure due to the 50 per cent US tariffs and

enhance their global competitiveness. Cotton imports attract 11 per cent duty in India.

“This is the highest ever imports in value terms,” said Atul S Ganatra, former President, CAI. The body estimates imports to touch 50 lakh bales of 170 kg each during 2025-26 cotton year ending September, up from 41 lakh bales in the previous year.

While 35 lakh bales have already come in, another 4-5 lakh bales of extra long staple cotton of above 32

mm are expected to come in the next few months.

Also, another 3 lakh bales of duty free cotton from Australia under the free trade agreement will come in during June-July, and another 3-4 lakh bales from the African countries at lower duty of 5.5 per cent are expected to come into the country, he said.

HIGHER REALISATION

Ramanuj Das Boob, a sourcing agent in Raichur, said cotton is imported from countries such as Brazil, Australia, US and West African countries. The imports of quality cotton were needed to help the textiles sector compete effectively in the overseas market.

Ganatra said spinning mills get a 2-3 per cent higher realisation from imported cotton, while the prices of domestic cotton are higher than international prices by about 8-10 per cent.

Cocoa slumps to more than 2-1/2-year lows

Reuters
London

London cocoa futures on ICE hit their lowest in 2-1/2 years on Tuesday as concern about unsold stocks of cocoa in the Ivory Coast and Ghana continued to weigh on prices.

London cocoa fell 3.2 per cent to £2,468 a tonnes after touching a 2-1/2 year low at £2,461. Ghana sharply reduced its fixed farmgate price by a third last week to reboot sales.

“This will make more cocoa available on the market, which is likely to put additional pressure on prices, as demand from chocolate producers is currently subdued,” Commerzbank said.

New York cocoa lost 4.9 per cent to \$3,492 a tonne after hitting its lowest in over two years at \$3,488.

Bengal expects a record 140-150 lt potato production in 2025-26

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

West Bengal is expected to witness a record potato production of around 140-150 lakh tonnes (t) for 2025-26, the highest in the last five years.

Total production of the spud in Bengal, the country’s second largest grower, was around 115 lt last year, which was also a bumper output. Favourable weather conditions are expected to lead to an over 20 per cent y-o-y jump in production.

“Potato harvesting has started. Production is expected to be around 140-150 lt this year. Favourable weather conditions are expected to result in the record jump in the output. Also, the area under cultivation has increased marginally,” Patit Paban De, a senior member



of the West Bengal Cold Storage Association, told *businessline*.

For the 2024-25 season, the area under potato cultivation was around 5.12 lakh hectares (lh). The harvesting season will continue till March.

COLD STORAGE

The West Bengal government has directed cold storage owners to open their facilities from March 1, when the loading of potatoes will commence.

Ayekart bets on asset-light, tech-led platform model to fix agri supply chain

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Agritech firm Ayekart is positioning itself as a network-driven enabler seeking to address structural inefficiencies in India’s largely unorganised food and agriculture supply chain through its digital agri infrastructure platform.

Launched in September 2021, the company’s core strategy revolves around organising two of the sector’s most fragmented participants — farmers and last-mile retailers — through an asset-light, technology-led model.

Debarshi Dutta, Co-founder and CEO, Ayekart, described the company’s business as that of a facilitator rather than a conventional trader or logistics op-



Debarshi Dutta, Co-founder and CEO, Ayekart

erator. Ayekart’s model connects producers, aggregators, processors, brands and retailers while leveraging existing infrastructure across the value chain.

The company handles about 15 commodities, including the sourcing of coffee from the Araku Valley, Dutta said.

PAYMENT ASSURANCE

A central feature of Ayekart’s model is payment assurance,

Datta said. Suppliers are paid immediately upon acceptance of goods, irrespective of buyer payment cycles.

Beyond sourcing, Ayekart has expanded into distribution, operating as an authorised channel partner for large consumer goods companies.

Technology remains central to the company’s strategy. Proprietary analytics integrate pricing signals, weather interfaces and policy variables to anticipate supply disruptions and price movements. “We are present in around 22 States on the sourcing side and active in the distribution business in around 10 States, mainly in North India,” he said.

So far, Ayekart has onboarded over 75,000 merchants and processed over a million transactions covering over 1,470 pin codes.

Aluminium: Go long at ₹306, stop-loss at ₹300

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl.research bureau

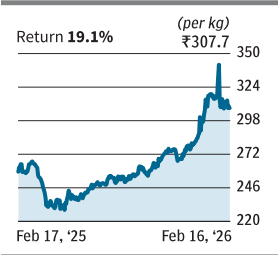
Aluminium futures is now quoted at ₹307 (per kg). The contract has not been trending since the beginning of the month.

COMMODITY CALL.

After witnessing very high volatility in the second half of January, the bulls and the bears appear to be negotiating, and there has not been a real winner yet.

Since early February, aluminium has largely been consolidating between ₹302 and ₹318. Only a clear break of this sideways band will give us cues about the direction of next price swing.

That said, currently trading at ₹307, the contract is hovering near the lower



boundary of the range. The 50-day moving average also lies at ₹307.

So, even though aluminium remains within a band, the likelihood of the contract rising on the back of the above-mentioned support is high. It could retest ₹318. So, traders could consider buying.

TRADE STRATEGY

Traders with high risk tolerance can buy aluminium futures at ₹306. Target and stop-loss can be ₹318 and ₹300 respectively.

Spice exporters to meet in Kochi amid tariff uncertainty, stricter residue norms

Our Bureau
Kochi

India’s spice industry will gather in Kochi next week for the 9th edition of the International Spice Conference (ISC 2026) amid tariff uncertainty, stricter residue norms and supply-chain realignments in global agri-trade.

Organised by the All India Spices Exporters Forum (AISEF), the conference will be held from February 23 to 26. The event comes at a time when India is recalibrating its trade strategies in response to shifting tariff regimes and heightened regulatory scrutiny in key importing markets, the organisers told reporters.

Emmanuel Nambusseril, Chairman, AISEF, said reciprocal trade measures underscored the vulnerability of agri-commodity exports to sudden policy shifts. “Even short-term duty escalations can redirect global sourcing and compress margins. Diversification of markets, greater focus on value addition and deeper regulatory preparedness are now structural necessities,” he said.

FUTURE GROWTH

The export environment is becoming increasingly science-driven and compliance-intensive.

Future growth will depend on laboratory validation, integration of digital traceability, alignment with Codex and importing-country standards, and climate-resilient sourcing. ISC 2026 is designed to facilitate regu-

Gold, silver prices slip on global cues

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Precious metals declined for the second consecutive day to a 10-day low on Tuesday on profit-taking, after a sharp rally in the past few months.

Most importantly, gold dropped below \$4,900 an ounce and silver to \$72 an ounce. In the domestic market, the yellow metal declined by ₹2,233 or one per cent to ₹151,865 per 10 g against ₹154,098 on Monday due to weak prospects in the global markets.

‘GOLD STILL UP’

However despite the recent fall, gold prices are still up 8 per cent compared with ₹140,449 on January 12, according to Indian Bullion and Jewellers Association data.

Similarly, silver prices dipped by ₹7,992 or 3 per cent to ₹232,955 a kg against ₹240,947 on Monday largely on global cues.

Gold and silver exchange traded funds also fell in sync. Gold ETFs declined 1.3-2.5 per cent, while silver ETFs fell 2.7-3.4 per cent. Over a one-year period, however, silver ETFs have more than doubled while gold ETFs have given over 75 per cent returns on an average.

ASIAN HOLIDAYS

On the MCX, gold for April delivery was down ₹1,780 or one per cent at ₹152,980 per 10 g.

The silver march contract declined by ₹7,166 or three per cent to ₹232,725.

Gold in the international market dropped by \$135 or over two per cent at \$4,852.51 an ounce. Silver was quoted at \$72.64 an ounce, down by 2.8 per cent.

Kaveri More, Commodity Analyst, Choice Broking, said gold and silver prices dropped as liquidity dried up due to holidays in most Asian markets.

QUICKLY.

NHAI to monetise 2 highways for ₹6,221 cr

New Delhi: NHAI has accepted National Highways Infra Trust's offer of ₹6,220.90 crore for the asset monetisation of two highway sections of 310 km across two States — the 255.97 km Amravati–Chikhali–Tarsod section of NH-53 in Maharashtra and the 54.38 km Gundugolanu–Chinna–Avutapalli section of NH-16 in Andhra Pradesh. The total NH assets monetised during FY26 are around ₹28,077 crore, said an official statement. **PII**

KNR Constructions bags ₹2,163-cr TN order

Hyderabad: KNR Constructions has received a ₹2,163-crore order to construct a four-lane elevated corridor along the East Coast Road from Thiruvannmiyur to Uthandi in Chennai. The signing of the concession agreement, however, is subject to the outcome of a case in the Madras High Court, the company informed the BSE. The flyover construction is expected to take about three years. **OUR BUREAU**

Tina Ambani skips ED summons again



New Delhi: Tina Ambani on Tuesday again skipped the Enforcement Directorate's summons issued for the second time seeking her appearance in a ₹40,000 crore worth money laundering case. On Wednesday, Anil Ambani has been asked to appear before the ED in connection with the case. **OUR BUREAU**

FIRs against 3 oil tankers suspected to be involved in smuggling off Mumbai

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

First Information Reports (FIR) have been registered against three oil tankers allegedly involved in a smuggling racket off Mumbai early this month.

All three ships have been arrested and are now at the Mumbai anchorage, said sources.

The FIRs have been registered at Mumbai's Yellow Gate Police Station, which is investigating the case, said sources.

JOINT OPERATION
The Coast Guard said on February 8 that it had busted an international oil smuggling racket in a co-ordinated sea-air operation that happened within the Exclusive Economic Zone.

British International Investment's climate commitments surpass \$1 billion in India

Our Bureau
New Delhi

British International Investment (BII) said on Tuesday that it has exceeded its commitment to invest \$1 billion in climate finance in India during the 2022-2026 strategy period.

Coinciding with the start of Mumbai Climate Week, the UK's development finance institution (DFI) also announced a ₹43 crore investment in Turno, an India-based EV battery infrastructure company that uses lifecycle intelligence and second-life battery deployment to make large-scale EV financing more economically viable.

The funding will support the launch of ElectricGo, Turno's new e-bus business unit, enabling the financing of 34 intercity electric

Centre reiterates Labour Codes will not hit TN's social security schemes

VIEWPOINT. Says unorganised workers' strike 'baseless' as clarification was given to the State govt a year ago

Our Bureau
New Delhi

A day after the Unorganised Workers Federation (UWF) started an indefinite hunger strike in Chennai on Monday, the Ministry of Labour & Employment said the concerns of the unions are "completely baseless and arise out of a misunderstanding" of the provisions of the four Labour Codes.

Ministry officials said clarifications had been made to the State government more than a year ago on January 2, 2025, that the State could "continue with its existing social security schemes after the implementation of the Code of Social Security, 2020," provided there is no inconsistency with the proposed central law. Correspondence between the Min-



WORKERS' WORRY. The demand of the UWF is that the State should protect existing sector specific labour welfare laws and ensure they do not get impacted by the Labour Codes

istry's Labour Reform Cell and the Secretary Labour Welfare & Skill Development Department, Tamil Nadu, accessed by *businessline* make this point.

The Ministry also noted in the written reply to the Labour Welfare & Skill Development Department, stating

that it is the responsibility of the State to "frame and notify, from time to time, suitable welfare schemes for unorganised workers including schemes relating to provident fund, employment injury benefit, housing, educational schemes for children, skill upgradation of workers, fu-

NCH facilitated refunds worth ₹52 cr in 9 months

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The National Consumer Helpline (NCH) has facilitated refunds amounting to ₹52 crore across 31 sectors in the last nine months.

The Department of Consumer Affairs said that 79,521 consumer grievances relating to refund claims have been addressed during the period from April 25, 2025 to January 31, 2026.

The refunds were secured at the pre-litigation stage, enabling consumers to obtain timely relief without approaching consumer commissions, it added.

"This flagship initiative of the department, plays a pivotal role in providing effective, accessible, and time-bound grievance redressal under the Consumer Protection Act, 2019. NCH operates through a convergence model where grievances are digitally forwarded to companies for resolution within defined timelines, with continuous monitoring and consumer feedback tracking," the statement added.

EXTENSIVE REACH
The e-commerce sector recorded the highest number of grievances, with 47,743 complaints, resulting in refunds exceeding ₹36 crore.



REFUND SPIKE. The e-commerce sector recorded the highest number of grievances, with 47,743 complaints, resulting in refunds exceeding ₹36 crore

The refund grievances in the e-commerce sector were reported from metropolitan cities as well as remote regions, underscoring the extensive reach and accessibility of the NCH as a pan-India

The Centre said TN could continue its social security schemes if they are not inconsistent with the proposed Central law

neral assistance and old age homes".

CLEAR'S STANCE
The Ministry had cleared the Centre's position on the issue after taking legal opinion on the matter raised by the Tamil Nadu government, as per letters exchanged between the two.

The overarching demand of the UWF for hitting the streets in Tamil Nadu is that the State government should protect existing sector spe-

cific labour welfare laws and ensure that social security measures are not impacted due to the labour codes.

The Federation specifically sought continuation of welfare boards for unorganised workers, such as those involved in construction, agriculture, domestic and in other informal sectors.

To that, Ministry officials pointed out that detailed clarifications were issued to the National Front of Indian Trade Unions (NFITU) and the Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh on the subjects raised, way back on December 10, 2025. The Ministry, through letters to both the unions, emphasised that the State welfare schemes would also continue, and there would be no adverse impact on Labour Welfare Boards set up by the States or on any existing social security schemes.

The travel & tourism sector followed e-commerce, with refunds of more than ₹4 crore

funds reinforces the government's commitment to strengthening consumer trust in digital marketplaces and service ecosystems. Also, encourages consumers to proactively utilise the National Consumer Helpline to safeguard their rights and seek timely redressal," the statement added.

Construction equipment sales slide 21% in January on monsoon impact, slower infra push

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The year started on a dull note for construction equipment manufacturers with a 21 per cent decline in retail sales in January when compared with a year ago. All the 12 manufacturers reported a decline in sales numbers, according to the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations' data.

In January 2026, the industry sold 6,834 units as against 8,660 units a year ago. The decline is attributed mainly to an erratic monsoon and slower infrastructure execution.

UNDER PRESSURE
Construction equipment sales continued to remain under pressure, declining 21 per cent y-o-y, due to high base impact and segment-specific recalibration, FADA said. The federation provides

Demand dip (in units)			
	Jan 2025	Jan 2026	Change (%)
JCB India	4,006	3,685	-8.0
Action Construction Equipment	1,049	652	-37.9
Escorts Kubota (Construction Equipment)	665	526	-20.9
Ajax Engineers	536	455	-15.1
Bull Machines	207	178	-14.0

Source: FADA Research

monthly retail vehicle registration data gathered from 1,403 out of 1,462 RTOs.

JCB India, a leader in the segment, reported an 8 per cent drop in sales in January 2026 to 3,685 units (4,006 units). However, it improved its market share to 53.92 per cent (46.26 per cent) in the last 12 months.

Action Construction Equipment, a far second, reported a 34.99 per cent decline in sales, followed by Escorts Kubota Ltd (Construction Equipment), which reported a 20 per cent

decline, according to the data.

DEMAND SOFTNESS
Escorts Kubota, in its January business update, said that while the construction equipment industry continued to see demand softness and slower infrastructure execution, industry volume in January 2026 had shown early signs of stabilisation. A gradual improvement is expected, supported by timely project awards, better on-ground execution and anticipated higher government



prone belts and expanding the cultivated area.

EFFORTS ON
The renewed push on river projects follows India's decision to put the treaty in abeyance after the Pahalgam attack and subsequent military action against Pakistan.

Since then, the government has stepped up progress on pending hydro-power schemes along the Chenab basin.

Last month, Union Power Minister Manohar Lal Khat-

spending in the coming year.

Poonam Upadhyay, Director, CRISIL Ratings, said construction equipment demand remained soft through most of the ongoing fiscal, with the trend continuing into January.

The moderation is largely driven by slower road execution, which accounts for nearly 40 per cent of the total equipment demand. The execution pace is expected to moderate to 23-25 km per day this fiscal from 25-27 km per day last year, reflecting weaker project awards and slower mobilisation.

An erratic monsoon, which delayed post-monsoon execution ramp-up, along with stabilising real estate activity, also weighed on demand. The decline also reflects a high base following strong fleet additions in FY23-FY24, with utilisation yet to fully ramp up to earlier peak levels, she said.

Reform express will roll on: Jaishankar

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai



S Jaishankar speaking at the inauguration of the Global Economic Cooperation 2026

The economic reforms initiated by the government will continue and facilitate businesses amid a fast-changing global order, said S Jaishankar, Minister of External Affairs, addressing 'Global Economic Cooperation 2026' in Mumbai on Tuesday.

He said the world had entered a volatile and uncertain era, possibly the most turbulent in living memory. Despite the challenges, India must search for opportunities and solutions, infinite or otherwise.

India's response is to further build national capabilities, address growth challenges comprehensively and deal with both short-term issues and long-term prospects. The reform express will continue to roll on, he said.

MORE INITIATIVES
Whether it is playing catch-up or treading uncharted paths, a range of new initiatives are underway. These cover semiconductors to microelectronics, defence, space, drones, shipping, renewables and most of all AI, he said.

India is engaging with international partners more intensively from a position of strength, and this was demonstrated in the recently concluded trade deals. India will also be more salient in the global calculus on production, services, technology, skills and talent, he said.

KEY FEATURES
"Replacements are hard to create, and we appear to be headed for a long twilight zone. This will be messy, risky, unpredictable, perhaps even dangerous. We have already seen this across different geographies," said

Jaishankar. Listing out six notable features of the current international scenario, he said the US is determined to re-industrialise at any cost, China's manufacturing and export focus continues unabated and may even expand, technology competition is intensifying, and polarising and energy trade flows are being significantly redefined.

NEW MINDSETS
This apart, he said new mindsets were encouraging greater risk-taking, including through military means and migration and even mobility. "We are today witnessing weaponisation of production, weaponisation of finance, leveraging of market shares and tightening of export controls. To add to all of this, there are now uncertainties on the demand side due to application of bilateral tariffs," he said.

India, with greater capabilities and confidence, is understandably negotiating mutually beneficial arrangements with most partners.

As a major food producer, this also means for a country such as India, fertilizer security. There will also be areas, such as critical minerals, where stronger international collaboration is necessary to ensure the required access.

SUPPLYCO

The Kerala State Civil Supplies Corporation Ltd.
Maveli Bhavan, Gandhi Nagar, Kochi - 682020
Mob: 9447740324
Website: www.supplyco.kerala.com, www.etenders.kerala.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE
(ONLY THROUGH ELECTRONIC TENDERING SYSTEM)

Supplyco invites E-Tender (Ref no.KSCSC/5133/2025-BP2) for the processing / milling, packing and supply of Matta Rice in Supplyco Sabari brand. Only suppliers possessing digital signatures will be permitted to participate in the E-Tender. Corrigendum if any, will be published in Supplyco website.
Last date: 25.02.2026 3.00 PM
For Tender Forms, Terms and Conditions and further details, please visit the above website

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thehindu **businessline.**

पावरग्रिड POWERGRID

NOTICE

1. Petition for determination of tariff under Section 62 read with Section 79 (1) (d) of Electricity Act, 2003 and under the Regulation 15 (1) (a) and Regulation 23 of Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (Conduct of Business) Regulations, 2023 read with Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (Terms and Condition of Tariff Regulations) 2019 and Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (Terms and Condition of Tariff Regulations) 2024 for **POWERGRID works associated with additional 400 kV feed to Goa.**

2. The beneficiaries of the above-mentioned Transmission system are: (1) Madhya Pradesh Power Management Company Ltd, Jabalpur (2) Chhattisgarh State Power Distribution Company Limited, Raipur (3) Gujarat Urja Vikas Nigam Ltd., Vadodara, (4) Electricity Department, Government of Goa, Panaji, (5) Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd., Mumbai, (6) DNHD Power Distribution Corporation Limited, Silvassa, (7) Goa Tamnar Transmission Projects Limited (GTPL), (8) Tamil Nadu Generation and Distribution Corporation Ltd, (9) Kerala State Electricity Board Ltd (KSEBL), (10) Electricity Department, Govt. Of Pondicherry, (11) Eastern Power Distribution Company Of Andhra Pradesh Limited (APEPDL), (12) Southern Power Distribution Company Of Andhra Pradesh Ltd (APSPDCL), (13) Andhra Pradesh Central Power Distribution Company Limited (APCPDCL), (14) Southern Power Distribution Company Of Telangana Limited (TSSPDCL), (15) Northern Power Distribution Company Of Telangana Limited (TGNPDCL), (16) Bangalore Electricity Supply Company Ltd. (BESCOM), (17) Gulbarga Electricity Supply Company Ltd. (GESCOM), (18) Hubli Electricity Supply Company Ltd. (HESCOM), (19) Mangalore Electricity Supply Company Ltd. (MESCOM), (20) Chamundeswari Electricity Supply Corporation Ltd. (CESC)

3. **Tariff details:**

a) **2019- 24 Block**

Asset detail	DOC/ ECOD	Completion Cost as on 31.03.2024	2019 -20	2020 -21	2021 -22	2022 -23	2023 -24	
Asset-A	05.07.2021	1135.94	Revised AFC based on trueing up	NA	NA	174.70	242.55	249.77
Asset-B	04.01.2022	959.73		NA	NA	30.35	137.62	146.95

b) **2024- 29 Block**

Asset detail	Completion Cost as on 31.03.2023	2024 -25	2025 -26	2026 -27	2027 -28	2028 -29	
Asset-A	1137.63	AFC	248.59	246.73	242.87	237.14	
Asset-B	972.42	AFC	168.26	166.69	165.45	165.02	162.30

4. A copy of this notice and of the application made for determination of tariff is posted on the website of the applicant at **www.powergrid.in**

5. The suggestions and objections, if any, on the proposals for determination of tariff contained in the petition may be filed by any person, including the beneficiaries, through the e-filing portal of the Commission or in writing before the Secretary, Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, 6th, 7th & 8th floor, Tower B, World Trade Centre, Naoraj Nagar, New Delhi - 110029 (or other address where the office of the Commission is situated), with a copy to the petitioner at the address of its corporate office within 30 days of publication of this notice.

Place: Gurgaon
Date: 10.02.2026

Sd/-
Sr. Deputy General Manager (Commercial)

POWER GRID CORPORATION OF INDIA LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)
Corp. Office : 'Saudamini', Plot No. 2, Sector-29, Gurgaon-122001, (Haryana) Tel : 0124-2571700-719
Reg. Office : B-9, Qutub Institutional Area, Katwara Sarai, New Delhi-110 016. Tel : 011-26560112, 26560121
www.powergrid.in, CIN : L40101DL1989SGO038121

A MAHARATNA PSU

QUICKLY.

Modi invites Bangladesh PM Rahman to visit India



New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi has invited Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman to visit India, the government has said. Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla handed over the Prime Minister's personal invitation to Rahman during his visit to Dhaka on Tuesday to attend the Bangladesh leader's swearing-in ceremony. OUR BUREAU

Zydus Lifesciences unveils low-cost breathing aid

Ahmedabad: Zydus Lifesciences Limited has launched PEPAIR, a handheld breathing device designed to help patients clear mucus and breathe more easily. The company described it as India's first affordable oscillating positive expiratory pressure device. It is drug-free, features a patented design and comes with a three-resistance system to support effective mucus clearance and improved breathing. The device is priced at ₹990 per unit, the company said. OUR BUREAU

Spectrum monetisation avenue shrinks for telcos after SC ruling

FUNDING INTACT. While the verdict goes beyond insolvency issues, telcos can borrow from banks: experts

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

The Supreme Court's recent ruling that spectrum is a national asset, not owned by telecom operators, is seen as a barrier to their ability to monetise it, but would not hinder their bank funding prospects, industry experts feel.

Last week, the apex court ruled that spectrum is not an asset that telecom companies can use in liquidation under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).

It also cannot serve as collateral for loans unless the government permits it, as the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) has a constitutional right to spectrum.

BANK FUNDING

While this decision goes beyond the question of bankruptcy, experts also said it would not prevent telecom companies from accessing bank funding.

According to Shriram Subramnian, Founder of proxy



OWNERSHIP DEFINED. The Supreme Court has ruled that spectrum is a national asset and cannot be treated as the property of telecom operators under the IBC

firm InGovern, the ruling will still not hurt companies like Vodafone Idea (Vi) seeking bank loans, since items such as equipment and real estate are usually flagged as collateral.

COLLATERAL COMFORT

Spectrum does not impact the sanctity of such deals. "Spectrum is more a comfort collateral. It, not being an asset, does not discourage

banks in terms of loans," he said. Sources close to telcos and representative bodies, too, said that there was no concern within the ecosystem with regard to the ruling, as telcos like Vi never projected spectrum anywhere in their bank loan plans.

However, the delabelling of spectrum as an asset may reduce the amount loaned by a bank, said Naqeeb Ahmed Kazia, Partner at CMS In-

dusLaw. "A bank assesses a telco's ability to repay loans based on assets. Since the asset value of spectrum cannot be considered, banks may reduce overall loan amount," he said, adding that in the case of an M&A deal, bundling spectrum in the deal will require DoT approval.

PUBLIC INTEREST

Speaking on the intent of the ruling, Kazia pointed out that if the court had not made its ruling, banks would have had control over the spectrum, with people in the country losing out.

The intent was to ensure that spectrum rights remain in the telecom sector.

Even so, domain experts called the ruling "unfair", considering telcos spent big bucks for acquiring the spectrum, leading to deferred payment situations.

"The government having the sole say in spectrum transfer and sale in matters related IBC is problematic. A government approval for transactions involving spectrum, admittedly, makes sense, given that the spectrum is a scarce public re-

source. However, preventing spectrum from being monetised is unfair to players who acquired it at considerable expense," said Mahesh Upal, Director of Com First (India).

FINAL WORD

The court's ruling takes a final word on an earlier NCLT decision, stating that spectrum cannot be considered an asset regardless of whether the spectrum is acquired through auction or assignment.

However, telecom expert Parag Kar pointed out that the court has not addressed whether DoT has failed as a trustee in maximising the value of spectrum for public welfare.

There is currently no welfare audit mechanism to check the value maximisation of spectrum.

As such, he argued that the next steps by authorities should be towards defining value beyond revenue, coming up with a plan to measure utilisation and welfare, aligning pricing with sustainability, and protecting competition.

Nvidia set to team up with top Indian manufacturers to build AI factories

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai



Vishal Dhupar

Nvidia will partner with India's largest manufacturers to build AI factories for design and manufacturing, accelerated by Nvidia AI infrastructure, CUDA-X and Omniverse libraries.

India's largest manufacturers are teaming up with global industrial software leaders like Cadence, Siemens, Synopsys among others to build software facilities to integrate AI and dramatically speeding up design cycles.

"By combining Nvidia's full-stack AI with India's manufacturing leadership, we aren't just witnessing the next age of industrialisation, we are building it," said Vishal Dhupar, Managing Director, South Asia, Nvidia.

The company noted that India is investing \$134 billion in manufacturing capacity across construction, automotive, renewable energy and robotics.

TECH INDUSTRY

India's tech industry is on track to reach \$500 billion in revenue by 2030, up from about \$250 billion in 2023, according to IBEF, citing mo-

mentum in AI from 38,000 GPUs secured in September.

"India's AI-driven future is well in motion. Nvidia is working closely with technology leaders across the country to accelerate this transformation and supercharge our growth. This diversity of partnership is critical," said Dhupar.

BUILDING AI STACK

Stating that AI is a five-layer game, spanning energy, ships, infrastructure, models and applications, Dhupar said Nvidia will be working with India visionaries to help people build the AI stack.

Indian AI native start-ups like Sarvam, BharatGen and Chariot are building sovereign AI models for the nation using Nvidia Nemotron, to serve India's unique needs, languages and diversity.

Beauty and personal care brands sniff big opportunity in fragrances segment

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Scenting big growth in the fragrances segment, beauty and personal care brands are amping up their perfume and deos strategy.

Meanwhile, new players having got a whiff of opportunity are entering this space with innovative products. At the same time, the category is witnessing an uptick in premiumisation led by global brands. Con-

sider this: Nykaa sold one fragrance every five seconds in 2025, while Myntra reported it to be the second fastest growing sub-category in the beauty segment.

Deepak Joshi, Senior Director — Category Management, Beauty and Personal Care, Myntra, said that there is a steadily rising consumer affinity for premium fragrances led by global brands. "In January 2026, fragrances witnessed 70 per cent year-on-year growth and in 2025 it emerged as the second

fastest-growing beauty sub-category. Last year, the demand for the subcategory peaked to over 1 million units with major gifting occasions." Joshi said that the fragrances are increasingly becoming a "high-growth and high-engagement" segment within Myntra's broader beauty and personal care portfolio.

SMELL THE MONEY

The robust growth trends have also led players to refine their strategies. In a re-

cent earnings call Nykaa's management said that it has launched a new fragrance-only store concept called Nykaa Perfumery as the segment has huge potential.

"We have already opened two stores in the past three months, and more to come. This is really to drive the adoption of fragrance by the Indian consumer. We think it's an under-penetrated category. So, through immersive experiences, technology, curated set of brands and very high-quality service in



the store, we are hoping to drive further adoption of this premium segment of fragrances in India," said

Anchit Nayar, ED & CEO, Beauty, Nykaa. Even in the mass fragrances, he pointed to body mists as a popular category.

Meanwhile, a host of new D2C brands have entered the space, heating up the segment even as established brands are diversifying into this lucrative area.

Sidhant Keshwani, Founder and CEO of Libas, said that the company has recently forayed in the "high-frequency and high-engagement" segment of

perfumes. "We are targeting sales of approximately 1-2 lakh units over the next two-three years, supported by expanded assortment and strong omni-channel visibility. Our objective is to build perfumes as a scalable lifestyle vertical within Libas, not just a seasonal experiment," he added.

ONLINE BUOYANCY

Kushal Bhatnagar, Associate Partner at RedSeer, noted that while the overall fragrance segment is growing at

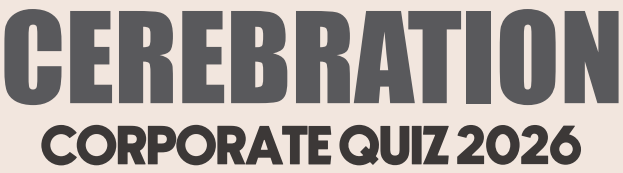
12 per cent growth rate y-o-y, the online fragrance category witnessed stronger growth of around 35 per cent year-on-year in CY2025. He said this is being fuelled by consumers becoming more conscious about hygiene, long-lasting-ness of fragrance, and quality of ingredients, thus driving upgrades. At the same time, the category is witnessing quick-commerce led acceleration as brands push fragrances for gifting bundles and festive editions, he added.



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